Annual Report on the Economic Status of the Profession, 2025–26

(JUNE 2026)

The central compensation story of 2025–26 is easy to state but disappointing: Faculty salaries rose, but inflation rose faster. Average salaries for full-time faculty members increased 2.3 percent in nominal terms from fall 2024 to fall 2025, while the Consumer Price Index for All Urban Consumers (CPI-U) increased 2.7 percent from December 2024 to December 2025. The result was a real decline of about 0.4 percent in average full-time faculty salaries. For continuing full-time faculty members—those who remained employed full time at the same institution from one year to the next—the year was somewhat better: Average salaries rose 3.4 percent in nominal terms and 0.7 percent in real terms. Even so, the broader recovery remains incomplete. Real average full-time faculty salaries are about 9.5 percent below their level in fall 2019, before the COVID-19 pandemic,[1] and about 5.8 percent below their level in fall 2008, the first full year of the subprime mortgage crisis.[2] The profession is still living with the aftereffects of these two major economic shocks.

Purchasing power remains under strain, and colleges and universities are operating in an environment shaped by political interference, research funding instability, uneven enrollment recovery, persistent contingency, and widening financial disparities.

This report begins by situating this year's compensation figures in the current economic and political context. It then presents the results of the 2025–26 AAUP Faculty Compensation Survey, including findings on full-time faculty salaries, continuing faculty salaries, gender salary gaps, fringe benefits, administrator compensation, and part-time faculty pay. From there, it widens the frame to include the academic workforce and the financial condition of colleges and universities. The report concludes with methodological guidance about how the survey should be read and with policy implications concerning tenure, shared governance, transparency, and the educational mission of colleges and universities.

Economic and Political Context

Faculty compensation cannot be understood apart from politics, inflation, and institutional instability. Salary schedules are shaped not only by annual budget decisions but also by public funding, enrollment, benefit costs, debt service, research support, and the growing imbalance between secure and contingent academic work.

Higher Education's Operating Environment

The broader context has been shaped in especially visible ways by recent federal action. Early in 2025, President Donald Trump issued Executive Order 14151, "Ending Radical and Wasteful Government DEI Programs and Preferencing," followed shortly by Executive Order 14173, "Ending Illegal Discrimination and Restoring Merit-Based Opportunity."

1. Nominal (non-inflation-adjusted) average salaries increased from $102,261 in fall 2019 to $117,068 in fall 2025, an increase of 14.5 percent, for a matched cohort of 726 institutions participating in both years, while the CPI-U increased 26.5 percent.

2. Nominal (non-inflation-adjusted) average salaries increased from $82,954 in fall 2008 to $120,905 in fall 2025, an increase of 45.7 percent, for a matched cohort of 693 institutions participating in both years, while the CPI-U increased 54.7 percent.

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Together, these orders signaled a sharp federal turn against diversity, equity, and inclusion efforts; Executive Order 14173 explicitly revoked the federal contractor regime established by President Lyndon B. Johnson's 1965 Executive Order 11246, which had shaped compliance expectations for colleges and universities for decades. Regardless of how institutions responded locally, the practical effect was to make the national policy environment more hostile to equity-oriented initiatives and more uncertain for institutions trying to maintain long-standing compliance and accountability practices.

The environment for research funding became similarly unstable. In February 2026, *The Chronicle of Higher Education* reported that higher education had, for the moment, avoided a major research funding "bloodbath" after Congress blocked changes to indirect-cost reimbursement that would have sharply reduced support for universities. The reprieve made a difference, but it was explicitly temporary and defensive, not evidence of a settled or supportive funding climate. Around the same time, a study published in the *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences* indicated that National Institutes of Health grant terminations fell disproportionately on women, particularly those early in their careers.[3] That uneven distribution is important because research funding is not merely a matter of laboratory budgets; it is often tied to salary support, course releases, advancement opportunities, and the cumulative prestige that later becomes embedded in institutional judgments of merit.

The Threat to Higher Education's Data Infrastructure

Since early 2025, the federal statistical infrastructure on which higher education analysis depends has faced critical, unprecedented strain. *ProPublica* reported in February 2025 that approximately $900 million in Institute of Education Sciences contracts had been canceled, and later reporting in *Inside Higher Ed* described a "gutted" National Center for Education Statistics trying to continue releasing data despite major staffing losses and doubts about the long-term integrity of the system.[4] For scholars, faculty leaders, and organizations such as the AAUP, this is not a side issue. It cuts directly into the profession's capacity to study itself and improve higher education. The AAUP, for example, has relied heavily on the Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS) and related federal datasets to document, analyze, and interpret tenure, contingency, workforce composition, finance, and institutional inequality. If those data become weaker, less timely, or less reliable, then future analysis of the profession's economic condition will be correspondingly impaired.

Political Interference and the Common Good

Political pressure has also taken more administrative forms. In March 2026, *The Chronicle of Higher Education* reported that the new Admissions and Consumer Transparency Supplement, or ACTS, imposed a substantial burden on institutional research offices by requiring large volumes of applicant, admissions, and enrollment data across multiple cycles.[5] That burden matters because the same offices charged with responding to politicized federal reporting mandates are often responsible for the institutional data infrastructure on which compensation analysis depends. The result is not just paperwork. It is a redistribution of institutional capacity away from reflective planning and toward defensive compliance.

Taken together, these developments sharpen long-standing AAUP concerns. Political interference, attacks on faculty expertise, and the expansion of corporate-style control structures threaten not only college and university budgets but also academic freedom, institutional autonomy, and the basic conditions of academic government. Compensation, in this setting, is one way to assess whether institutions are protecting the people and practices that sustain teaching, research, and shared governance—or whether they are focused primarily on crisis management, administrative centralization, and externally imposed priorities.

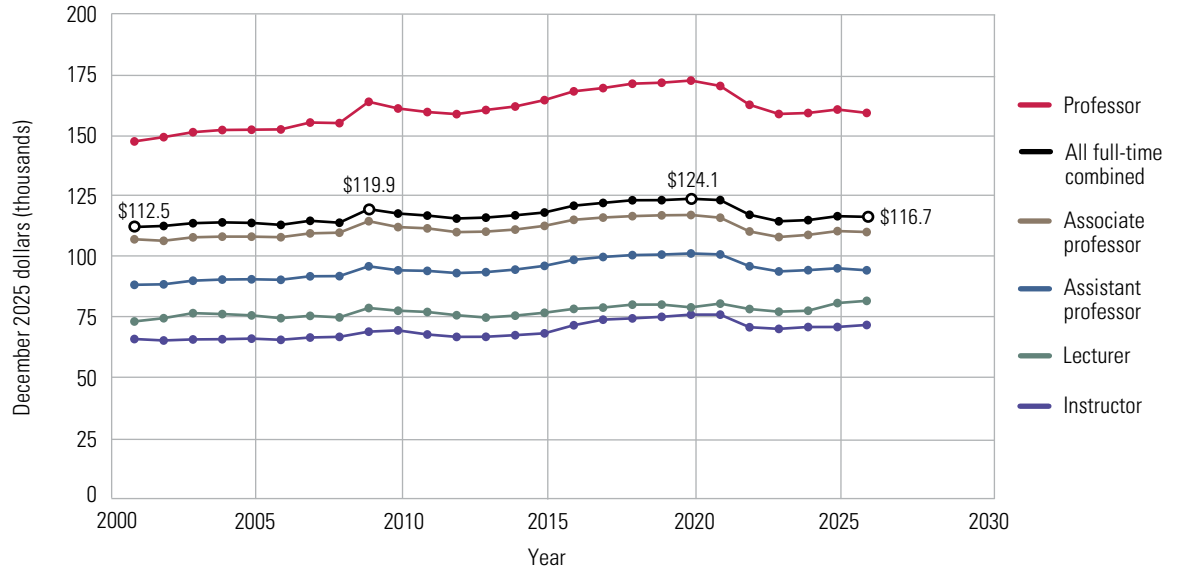
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5. Eric Hoover, "How Trump's Demand for Admissions Data Is Burdening Your College," *Chronicle of Higher Education*, March 18, 2026, https://www.chronicle.com/article/how-trumps-demand-for-admissions-data-is-burdening-your-college.

FIGURE 1

Real average full-time faculty salaries remain below their levels before the COVID-19 recession began in 2020 and below their levels in fall 2008, the first full year of the subprime mortgage crisis.



Note: This figure presents average salaries for full-time faculty members by academic rank from fall 2000 through fall 2025. Figures represent average full-time faculty salaries previously published in the *Annual Report on the Economic Status of the Profession*, adjusted for inflation (December 2025 dollars) using the Consumer Price Index Retroactive Series (R-CPI-U-RS), which includes revised measures to reflect current methodologies. Salaries may vary from previously published values. Labeled points indicate academic years in which recessions occurred—fall 2000, fall 2008, and fall 2019—and the most recent academic year, fall 2025.

Source: AAUP Faculty Compensation Survey, US Bureau of Labor Statistics Consumer Price Index Retroactive Series (R-CPI-U-RS).

Findings from the AAUP's 2025–26 Faculty Compensation Survey

The AAUP's Faculty Compensation Survey—the empirical core of this report—provides the profession with one of its most substantial annual benchmarking resources. The 2025–26 survey concluded in March 2026, with 768 colleges and universities providing data on 359,234 full-time faculty members, 664 institutions providing data on 125,149 part-time faculty members, and 484 institutions reporting data on senior administrators. Participants represented a broad cross section of institutions of higher education, including approximately 285 doctoral universities, 210 regional universities, 190 liberal arts colleges, 65 community colleges, and 160 minority-serving institutions.

Full-Time Faculty Salaries

Average salaries for full-time faculty members, all ranks combined, rose 2.3 percent in nominal terms from fall 2024 to fall 2025. That followed three consecutive years in which annual increases were at least 3.8 percent. Yet the inflation rate matters just as much as the salary rate. Because the CPI-U increased by 2.7 percent from December 2024 to December 2025, real average salary fell by about 0.4 percent this year (see table A). Figure 1, which displays real (inflation-adjusted) full-time faculty salaries since fall 2000, shows a picture of incomplete recovery after repeated setbacks. Real average salaries remain about 9.5 percent below fall 2019 and about 5.8 percent below fall 2008.

In a matched-year comparison of 752 institutions that reported comparable full-time salary data in both 2024–25 and 2025–26, salary growth outpaced inflation at only 40.6 percent of institutions, or 305 campuses. That was a lower share than in the prior two matched-year comparisons, when 47.7 percent and 45.1 percent of institutions, respectively, reported real increases. In nominal terms, by contrast, 615 of

How to interpret full-time faculty salary
Full-time faculty salary in the AAUP Faculty Compensation Survey refers to contracted academic-year salary for full-time faculty members. It excludes summer teaching, stipends, extra load, and most supplemental forms of remuneration. For faculty on eleven- or twelve-month appointments, salary is converted to an academic-year basis using the institution's official factor or an equivalent conversion formula. Salaries for full-time faculty on reduced load (for example, 0.75 FTE) are converted to their full-load equivalents (1.0 FTE). Major exclusions from the full-time survey include short-term appointments, preclinical and clinical medical faculty paid on different scales, part-time faculty, most administrators, graduate assistants, faculty on unpaid leave, and obvious salary outliers.

752 institutions, or 81.8 percent, reported an increase in average salary.

Absolute salary levels continued to vary sharply by rank and institutional type (see survey report table 1). At the low end, average salary was $63,155 for instructors at associate's institutions with ranking systems. At the high end, average salary was $184,361 for full professors at doctoral institutions. Across all AAUP categories combined except institutions without ranks, average salaries were $163,836 for full professors, $113,427 for associate professors, $97,232 for assistant professors, $74,087 for instructors, $84,292 for lecturers, $78,520 for faculty with no rank, and $119,836 for full-time faculty overall.

Differences by type of institution were equally substantial: Average salary across faculty ranks combined was $131,678 at doctoral institutions, $96,817 at master's institutions, $97,924 at baccalaureate institutions, and $89,692 at associate's institutions with ranks. Public institutions averaged $114,703 overall, private-independent institutions $145,148, and religiously affiliated institutions $105,925.

One-year changes also differed across institutional type. Survey report table 2 presents the annual percentage change in average salary for full-time faculty members from fall 2024 to fall 2025.[6] Nominal average salaries increased 2.4 percent among public institutions, 1.5 percent among private-independent institutions, and 2.5 percent among religiously affiliated institutions. By AAUP category, nominal increases were 2.2 percent at doctoral institutions, 2.1 percent at master's institutions, 3.1 percent at baccalaureate institutions, 4.2 percent at associate's institutions with ranks, and 1.6 percent at associate's institutions without ranks.

Survey report table 3 presents full-time faculty salaries by gender; salary equity will be discussed in a later section. Survey report table 4 presents salaries by region, which is important because a salary figure does not travel unchanged across the country. Institutions can shift meaningfully in comparative standing once local costs are taken into account. Survey report table 5, meanwhile, presents percentile distributions of institutions. Percentiles can show, in a practical sense, where institutions sit within the broader salary landscape. Survey report tables 6 and 7 complete the picture by showing the rank, tenure, and gender composition of the full-time faculty represented in the survey, a reminder that salary averages are inseparable from who occupies which positions.

Continuing Full-Time Faculty Salaries

The continuing faculty measure asks a different question from the all-faculty average. Instead of comparing institutional averages across years and allowing new hires, departures, promotions, and workforce restructuring to shape the result, it tracks those faculty members who remained employed full time at the same institution from one year to the next. That is why it often gives a better approximation of what happened to salaries for faculty already in the profession. In 2025–26, that distinction matters a great deal. Average salaries for continuing full-time faculty members rose 3.4 percent in nominal terms and 0.7 percent in real terms, making this the third consecutive year in which salary growth for continuing faculty members

6. Beginning in 2024–25, the percentage change in salary for all full-time faculty members listed in survey report table 2 represents the change among institutions reporting full-time faculty salary data in both the current year and the prior year. In contrast, previous versions of table 2 were calculated as a simple percentage change in the values published in survey report table 1, which may have distorted results because some institutions did not participate in both years.

TABLE A

Annual percentage change in average salaries for full-time faculty, by academic rank, in nominal and real terms for institutions reporting comparable data for adjacent one-year periods, and annual percentage change in the Consumer Price Index, 1971–72 to 2025–26

	NOMINAL TERMS					REAL TERMS					
Interval	Prof.	Assoc.	Asst.	Inst.	All ranks	Prof.	Assoc.	Asst.	Inst.	All ranks	Change in CPI-U
1971–72 to 1972–73	4.3	4.2	4.1	3.9	4.1	0.9	0.8	0.7	0.5	0.7	3.4
1972–73 to 1973–74	5.2	5.2	4.8	4.7	5.1	–3.2	–3.2	–3.6	–3.7	–3.3	8.7
1973–74 to 1974–75	5.8	5.9	5.7	5.8	5.8	–5.8	–5.7	–5.9	–5.8	–5.8	12.3
1974–75 to 1975–76	6.2	5.9	5.7	6.1	6.0	–0.7	–1.0	–1.2	–0.8	–0.9	6.9
1975–76 to 1976–77	4.7	4.7	4.7	4.7	4.7	–0.2	–0.2	–0.2	–0.2	–0.2	4.9
1976–77 to 1977–78	5.2	5.4	5.3	5.4	5.3	–1.4	–1.2	–1.3	–1.2	–1.3	6.7
1977–78 to 1978–79	5.6	5.8	5.9	6.0	5.8	–2.0	–1.9	–1.8	–1.7	–1.9	7.8
1978–79 to 1979–80	7.5	7.0	6.8	6.4	7.1	–3.0	–3.5	–3.7	–4.0	–3.4	10.9
1979–80 to 1980–81	8.8	8.5	8.8	8.6	8.7	–1.8	–2.1	–1.8	–2.0	–1.9	10.8
1980–81 to 1981–82	9.0	8.8	9.1	8.2	9.0	0.6	0.5	0.7	–0.1	0.6	8.3
1981–82 to 1982–83	6.3	6.3	6.8	6.7	6.4	1.2	1.2	1.7	1.6	1.3	5.0
1982–83 to 1983–84	4.6	4.4	5.0	5.1	4.7	0.8	0.6	1.2	1.3	0.9	3.8
1983–84 to 1984–85	6.7	6.4	6.6	6.2	6.6	2.8	2.5	2.7	2.3	2.7	3.8
1984–85 to 1985–86	6.1	5.9	6.2	5.9	6.1	2.4	2.2	2.5	2.2	2.4	3.6
1985–86 to 1986–87	6.0	5.8	5.7	4.9	5.9	5.1	4.9	4.8	4.0	5.0	0.9
1986–87 to 1987–88	5.0	4.8	4.9	3.8	4.9	0.9	0.7	0.8	–0.3	0.8	4.1
1987–88 to 1988–89	5.8	6.7	6.0	5.3	5.8	1.8	2.7	2.0	1.3	1.8	3.9
1988–89 to 1989–90	6.3	6.3	6.3	5.4	6.1	2.0	2.0	2.0	1.2	1.8	4.2
1989–90 to 1990–91	5.5	5.3	5.5	5.0	5.4	–0.2	–0.4	–0.2	–0.7	–0.3	5.7
1990–91 to 1991–92	3.4	3.5	3.8	3.9	3.5	1.0	1.1	1.4	1.5	1.1	2.4
1991–92 to 1992–93	2.6	2.3	2.6	2.3	2.5	0.1	–0.2	0.1	–0.2	0.0	2.5
1992–93 to 1993–94	3.0	3.1	3.0	3.2	3.0	0.7	0.8	0.7	0.9	0.7	2.3
1993–94 to 1994–95	3.4	3.4	3.2	3.5	3.4	1.2	1.2	1.0	1.3	1.2	2.2
1994–95 to 1995–96	3.1	2.9	2.7	2.6	2.9	0.8	0.6	0.4	0.3	0.6	2.3
1995–96 to 1996–97	2.9	3.0	2.4	3.2	3.0	–0.2	–0.1	–0.7	0.1	–0.1	3.1
1996–97 to 1997–98	3.6	3.2	2.8	2.6	3.3	2.0	1.6	1.2	1.0	1.7	1.5
1997–98 to 1998–99	4.0	3.6	3.5	2.9	3.6	2.6	2.2	2.1	1.5	2.2	1.4
1998–99 to 1999–00	4.3	4.0	3.9	3.7	3.7	1.6	1.3	1.2	1.0	1.0	2.7
1999–00 to 2000–01	4.4	3.9	4.4	3.6	3.5	1.0	0.5	1.0	0.2	0.1	3.4
2000–01 to 2001–02	4.2	3.8	4.8	4.2	3.8	2.6	2.2	3.2	2.6	2.2	1.6
2001–02 to 2002–03	3.4	3.1	3.8	2.2	3.0	1.0	0.7	1.4	–0.2	0.6	2.4
2002–03 to 2003–04	2.4	2.0	2.3	2.0	2.1	0.5	0.1	0.4	0.1	0.2	1.9
2003–04 to 2004–05	3.4	3.0	3.2	2.7	2.8	0.1	–0.2	–0.1	–0.5	–0.4	3.3
2004–05 to 2005–06	3.7	3.3	3.3	3.2	3.1	0.3	–0.1	–0.1	–0.2	–0.3	3.4
2005–06 to 2006–07	4.2	3.9	4.1	3.9	3.8	1.6	1.3	1.5	1.3	1.2	2.6
2006–07 to 2007–08	4.3	4.1	4.1	3.9	3.8	0.2	0.0	0.0	–0.2	–0.3	4.1
2007–08 to 2008–09	3.8	3.6	3.6	3.3	3.4	3.7	3.5	3.5	3.2	3.3	0.1
2008–09 to 2009–10	1.0	0.8	1.1	1.4	1.2	–1.7	–1.9	–1.6	–1.3	–1.5	2.7
2009–10 to 2010–11	1.4	1.2	1.5	0.9	1.4	–0.1	–0.3	–0.0	–0.6	–0.1	1.5
2010–11 to 2011–12	2.2	1.6	2.1	1.7	1.8	–0.8	–1.3	–0.9	–1.3	–1.1	3.0
2011–12 to 2012–13	2.1	1.7	2.1	2.0	1.7	0.3	–0.1	0.3	0.2	–0.1	1.8
2012–13 to 2013–14	2.4	2.1	2.3	2.0	2.2	0.8	0.5	0.7	0.4	0.6	1.5
2013–14 to 2014–15	2.6	2.4	2.6	2.4	2.2	1.8	1.6	1.8	1.6	1.4	0.8
2014–15 to 2015–16	3.7	3.5	4.0	n.d.	4.0	2.9	2.7	3.2	n.d.	3.2	0.8
2015–16 to 2016–17	2.4	2.6	2.9	2.7	2.5	0.3	0.5	0.8	0.6	0.4	2.1
2016–17 to 2017–18	3.0	2.5	2.8	3.6	2.8	0.9	0.4	0.7	1.5	0.7	2.1
2017–18 to 2018–19	2.2	2.2	2.1	1.9	2.0	0.3	0.3	0.2	–0.0	0.1	1.9
2018–19 to 2019–20	2.8	2.4	2.8	–3.0	2.8	0.5	0.1	0.5	–5.2	0.5	2.3
2019–20 to 2020–21	0.1	0.5	1.0	1.4	1.0	–1.3	–0.9	–0.4	–0.0	–0.4	1.4
2020–21 to 2021–22	2.3	2.0	2.0	–0.1	2.0	–4.5	–4.9	–4.8	–6.8	–4.9	7.2
2021–22 to 2022–23	4.2	4.3	4.2	5.5	4.1	–2.2	–2.1	–2.2	–1.0	–2.3	6.5
2022–23 to 2023–24	3.7	4.2	4.0	4.4	3.8	0.3	0.8	0.6	1.0	0.4	3.4
2023–24 to 2024–25	3.3	3.7	3.1	2.1	3.8	0.4	0.8	0.2	–0.8	0.9	2.9
2024–25 to 2025–26	1.6	2.3	1.8	3.2	2.3	–1.1	–0.3	–0.8	0.5	–0.4	2.7

Note: The annual percentage change in real terms is calculated as the annual percentage change in nominal terms adjusted for the December-to-December percentage change in the Consumer Price Index for All Urban Consumers (CPI-U) from the US Bureau of Labor Statistics. From 1978–79 through 2024–25, CPI-U values are from the Consumer Price Index Retroactive Series (R-CPI-U-RS), which includes revised measures to reflect current methodologies. Values may vary from previously published values. N.d. = no data.

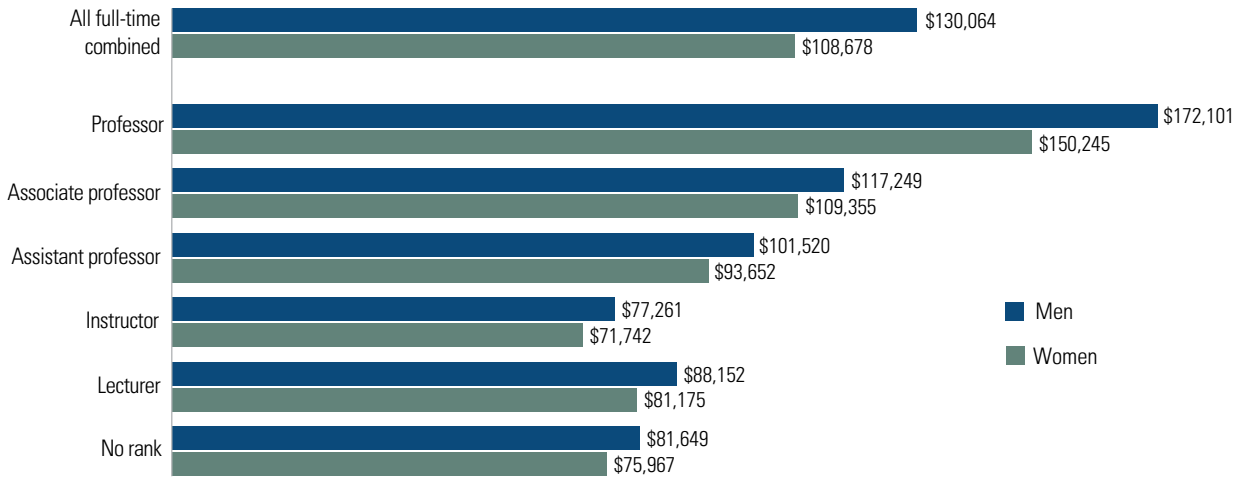
TABLE B

Annual percentage change in average salaries for continuing full-time faculty, by academic rank, in nominal and real terms for institutions reporting comparable data for adjacent one-year periods, and annual percentage change in the Consumer Price Index, 1971–72 to 2025–26

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Interval	Prof.	Assoc.	Asst.	Inst.	All ranks	Prof.	Assoc.	Asst.	Inst.	All ranks	Change in CPI-U
1971–72 to 1972–73	4.7	5.7	5.9	6.3	5.5	1.3	2.2	2.4	2.8	2.0	3.4
1972–73 to 1973–74	5.4	6.3	6.5	7.0	6.1	–3.0	–2.2	–2.0	–1.6	–2.4	8.7
1973–74 to 1974–75	6.7	7.4	7.9	8.7	7.4	–5.0	–4.4	–4.0	–3.2	–4.4	12.3
1974–75 to 1975–76	7.1	7.7	8.0	8.5	7.6	0.2	0.7	1.0	1.5	0.6	6.9
1975–76 to 1976–77	6.2	6.8	7.2	7.4	6.7	1.3	1.8	2.2	2.4	1.8	4.9
1976–77 to 1977–78	5.9	6.0	5.9	5.9	5.9	–0.8	–0.7	–0.8	–0.8	–0.8	6.7
1977–78 to 1978–79	6.9	7.6	8.0	8.4	7.4	–0.8	–0.2	0.2	0.6	–0.4	7.8
1978–79 to 1979–80	7.8	8.2	8.7	8.9	8.1	–2.8	–2.4	–1.9	–1.8	–2.5	10.9
1979–80 to 1980–81	9.6	10.0	10.6	10.6	10.0	–1.1	–0.7	–0.2	–0.2	–0.7	10.8
1980–81 to 1981–82	9.4	10.0	10.7	10.6	9.9	1.0	1.6	2.2	2.1	1.5	8.3
1981–82 to 1982–83	7.5	7.8	8.5	8.3	7.9	2.4	2.6	3.3	3.1	2.7	5.0
1982–83 to 1983–84	5.4	5.7	6.3	5.9	5.7	1.6	1.8	2.4	2.0	1.8	3.8
1983–84 to 1984–85	6.7	7.2	7.8	7.9	7.1	2.8	3.2	3.8	3.9	3.1	3.8
1984–85 to 1985–86	7.0	7.4	7.9	7.6	7.3	3.3	3.7	4.2	3.9	3.6	3.6
1985–86 to 1986–87	6.3	6.7	7.0	6.5	6.6	5.4	5.8	6.1	5.6	5.7	0.9
1986–87 to 1987–88	6.1	6.6	7.1	6.9	6.5	2.0	2.4	2.9	2.7	2.3	4.1
1987–88 to 1988–89	6.4	7.1	7.6	7.4	6.8	2.4	3.1	3.6	3.4	2.8	3.9
1988–89 to 1989–90	6.9	7.4	7.8	7.5	7.3	2.6	3.1	3.5	3.2	3.0	4.2
1989–90 to 1990–91	6.1	6.8	7.2	7.0	6.6	0.4	1.0	1.4	1.2	0.8	5.7
1990–91 to 1991–92	3.9	4.5	4.9	5.1	4.3	1.5	2.1	2.5	2.7	1.9	2.4
1991–92 to 1992–93	3.2	3.7	4.2	4.4	3.6	0.7	1.2	1.7	1.9	1.1	2.5
1992–93 to 1993–94	3.8	4.4	4.7	4.5	4.2	1.5	2.1	2.4	2.2	1.9	2.3
1993–94 to 1994–95	4.1	4.7	4.9	4.9	4.6	1.9	2.5	2.7	2.7	2.4	2.2
1994–95 to 1995–96	3.7	4.1	4.5	4.4	4.0	1.4	1.8	2.2	2.1	1.7	2.3
1995–96 to 1996–97	3.0	4.0	4.2	4.6	3.5	–0.1	0.9	1.1	1.5	0.4	3.1
1996–97 to 1997–98	4.0	4.6	4.8	5.0	4.3	2.4	3.0	3.2	3.4	2.7	1.5
1997–98 to 1998–99	4.5	5.0	5.3	5.3	4.8	3.1	3.6	3.9	3.9	3.4	1.4
1998–99 to 1999–00	4.5	4.9	5.4	5.3	4.8	1.7	2.1	2.6	2.5	2.0	2.7
1999–00 to 2000–01	5.0	5.4	5.8	5.8	5.3	1.6	2.0	2.4	2.4	1.9	3.4
2000–01 to 2001–02	4.8	5.1	5.7	5.4	5.0	3.2	3.5	4.1	3.8	3.4	1.6
2001–02 to 2002–03	4.1	4.4	4.7	4.5	4.3	1.7	2.0	2.3	2.1	1.9	2.4
2002–03 to 2003–04	2.8	3.3	3.5	3.8	3.1	0.9	1.4	1.6	1.9	1.2	1.9
2003–04 to 2004–05	4.5	4.7	4.8	4.7	4.5	1.2	1.4	1.5	1.4	1.2	3.3
2004–05 to 2005–06	4.5	4.7	4.8	4.4	4.4	1.1	1.3	1.4	1.0	1.0	3.4
2005–06 to 2006–07	4.5	5.3	5.4	5.1	5.0	1.9	2.7	2.8	2.5	2.4	2.6
2006–07 to 2007–08	4.5	5.4	5.4	5.7	5.1	0.4	1.3	1.3	1.5	1.0	4.1
2007–08 to 2008–09	4.5	5.0	5.2	6.0	4.9	4.4	4.9	5.1	5.9	4.8	0.1
2008–09 to 2009–10	1.4	2.1	2.1	2.1	1.8	–1.3	–0.6	–0.6	–0.6	–0.9	2.7
2009–10 to 2010–11	2.2	2.7	2.8	2.3	2.5	0.7	1.2	1.3	0.8	1.0	1.5
2010–11 to 2011–12	2.7	3.1	3.3	3.2	2.9	–0.3	0.1	0.3	0.2	–0.0	3.0
2011–12 to 2012–13	2.9	3.4	3.5	3.6	3.2	1.1	1.6	1.7	1.8	1.4	1.8
2012–13 to 2013–14	3.0	3.5	3.7	3.6	3.4	1.4	2.0	2.1	2.0	1.8	1.5
2013–14 to 2014–15	3.2	3.7	3.8	3.8	3.7	2.4	2.9	2.9	2.9	2.9	0.8
2014–15 to 2015–16	2.9	3.7	3.8	4.3	3.4	2.1	2.9	3.0	3.5	2.6	0.8
2015–16 to 2016–17	2.7	3.3	3.6	3.6	3.0	0.6	1.2	1.5	1.5	0.9	2.1
2016–17 to 2017–18	2.9	3.4	3.5	3.6	3.3	0.8	1.3	1.4	1.5	1.2	2.1
2017–18 to 2018–19	2.7	3.3	3.4	3.7	3.1	0.7	1.4	1.5	1.8	1.2	1.9
2018–19 to 2019–20	2.8	3.3	3.6	3.4	3.2	0.5	1.0	1.3	1.1	0.9	2.3
2019–20 to 2020–21	0.8	1.4	1.5	1.5	1.2	–0.6	–0.0	0.1	0.1	–0.2	1.4
2020–21 to 2021–22	2.5	3.1	3.2	3.3	2.9	–4.4	–3.8	–3.7	–3.6	–4.0	7.2
2021–22 to 2022–23	4.3	4.9	5.4	5.6	4.8	–2.1	–1.5	–1.1	–0.9	–1.6	6.5
2022–23 to 2023–24	4.3	5.2	5.4	5.5	4.9	0.9	1.8	2.0	2.1	1.5	3.4
2023–24 to 2024–25	4.2	5.0	5.1	4.9	4.7	1.3	2.1	2.2	2.0	1.8	2.9
2024–25 to 2025–26	2.9	3.8	3.8	3.9	3.4	0.2	1.1	1.1	1.2	0.7	2.7

Note: Figures for continuing faculty represent the annual percentage change in average salary for faculty employed at the same institution in both years and exclude salaries for new hires and departed faculty. The annual percentage change in real terms is calculated as the annual percentage change in nominal terms adjusted for the December-to-December percentage change in the Consumer Price Index for All Urban Consumers (CPI-U) from the US Bureau of Labor Statistics. From 1978–79 through 2024–25, CPI-U values are from the Consumer Price Index Retroactive Series (R-CPI-U-RS), which includes revised measures to reflect current methodologies. Values may vary from previously published values.

FIGURE 2
Average salaries for full-time women faculty members are lower than average salaries for men at all ranks.



Note: This figure presents average salaries for men and women full-time faculty members by academic rank in fall 2025. The figure is based on 768 institutions with faculty ranking systems reporting full-time faculty salary data. The figure excludes eighteen associate's institutions without faculty ranking systems. Reporting on faculty members with unknown or nonbinary gender identities is not possible at this time because reporting categories are generally aligned with those of the IPEDS Human Resources survey, which assumes binary genders (men or women).
Source: AAUP Faculty Compensation Survey.

exceeded inflation (see table B).

By rank, nominal continuing faculty salary growth was 2.9 percent for full professors, 3.8 percent for associate professors, 3.8 percent for assistant professors, and 3.9 percent for instructors. After adjustment for inflation, those become real increases of 0.2 percent, 1.1 percent, 1.1 percent, and 1.2 percent, respectively. Thus, the strongest real gains were concentrated below the full professor rank, as we would expect; associate professors, assistant professors, and instructors are the most likely to receive promotions and commensurate pay increases.

Variation across institutional types remained considerable. Among continuing full-time faculty, nominal salary growth ranged from 2.7 percent in private-independent doctoral institutions to 6.3 percent in public associate's institutions with ranking systems (see survey report table 2). Only five institutions, or roughly 0.7 percent of those reporting continuing faculty salary change, recorded a decline in average continuing faculty salaries. After adjusting for inflation, however, only about 62.7 percent of institutions reported a real increase.

How to interpret continuing full-time faculty salary
The change in continuing full-time faculty salary is the average year-over-year salary change for faculty members who remained employed full time at the same institution and at the same contract length in both years; it excludes new hires and departed faculty and includes promotions and other salary changes.

Salary Equity

Across all AAUP categories combined except institutions without ranks, women earned an average of $108,678, compared with $130,064 for men (see figure 2 and survey report table 3), meaning that women's average full-time salary was 83.6 percent of men's.[7] That figure sits 2.9 percentage points above the

7. Reporting on nonbinary faculty members or faculty members whose gender is unknown is not possible at this time because the IPEDS Human Resources survey assumes binary genders (men or women), stating that "it is up to the institution to decide how best to handle reporting individuals whose gender is unknown." AAUP reporting categories generally follow IPEDS reporting categories to minimize the reporting burden on survey respondents.

Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) finding that women's median weekly earnings were 80.7 percent of men's across all sectors in the third quarter of 2025.[8]

Within rank, the largest disparity remained at the full professor level. Women full professors earned an average of $150,245, compared with $172,101 for men, a salary-equity ratio of 87.3. Among other ranks, the ratios were narrower but still unequal, ranging from 91.2 for lecturers to 93.3 for associate professors. The same structural lesson that has been discussed in previous reports holds here as well: The overall gender salary-equity ratio for all ranks combined (83.6) is lower than the ratio for any individual rank in large part because women remain underrepresented in the higher-paid segments of the full-time faculty workforce.

Survey report tables 6 and 7 make that compositional point concrete. Women constituted 47.9 percent of full-time faculty overall in 2025–26 but only 37.8 percent of full professors. They were much more prevalent among assistant professors, instructors, lecturers, and faculty members in unranked positions. Women were also less represented in doctoral institutions, which pay the highest average salaries, and more represented in associate's institutions, which generally pay less.

Finally, although the annual compensation survey does not collect data by race and ethnicity,[9] recent AAUP data snapshots using federal data show that underrepresented minority faculty remain less likely than white or Asian faculty to hold tenured appointments and remain underrepresented at the ranks and institutional types that carry the highest compensation. Stated plainly, the survey cannot provide a national race-based salary-equity ratio parallel to the gender ratio above. It does not follow, however, that race-based salary inequity is absent.

Full-Time Faculty Fringe Benefits

If salary is the most visible part of compensation, fringe benefits are often the most quietly consequential. In 2025–26, 98.4 percent of full-time faculty members were eligible to participate in retirement plans, and 96.1 percent actually participated (see survey report table 8).[10] Average employer expenditures were $13,281 for covered faculty members, or 11.1 percent of average salary, and $13,293 for participating faculty members, or 11.2 percent of salary. Yet the overall figures conceal large differences by institutional control (public versus private) and religious affiliation. Employer contributions to retirement plans for those covered were equivalent to 12.2 percent of average salary at public institutions, 8.9 percent at private-independent institutions, and 8.0 percent at religiously affiliated institutions.

How to interpret full-time faculty fringe benefits
Benefit expenditures represent the projected total annual expenditure for the current academic year by the institution, state, and local government for each benefit, excluding employee contributions.

Medical benefits were similarly widespread in eligibility but uneven in participation and effective value. In 2025–26, 99.0 percent of full-time faculty members were eligible for medical insurance, and 91.7 percent participated (see survey report table 9). Average employer expenditures were $15,034 for covered faculty members, equal to 12.5 percent of average salary, and $15,147 for participating faculty members, equal to 12.8 percent. The percentage eligible varied little by institutional type, but participation ranged from a low of 83.9 percent in religiously affiliated institutions to a high of 93.6 percent in public institutions. Employer contributions to medical insurance premiums for those covered were equivalent to 12.9 percent of average salary at public institutions, 11.3 percent at private-independent institutions, and 12.2 percent at religiously affiliated institutions.

Dependent tuition benefits remained one of the clearest areas of differentiation among types of institution. About 94 percent of institutions provided some

8. US Bureau of Labor Statistics, "Usual Weekly Earnings of Wage and Salary Workers News Release," December 4, 2025, https://www.bls.gov/news.release/archives/wkyeng_12042025.htm. BLS did not produce data on median weekly earnings for the fourth quarter of 2025.

9. Privacy concerns, reporting burden, and small population sizes within data subsets that risk reidentification of individuals—especially at private institutions—make reporting of salary data by race and ethnicity difficult to sustain in this format.

10. In 2024–25, the AAUP Faculty Compensation Survey began collecting data on the number of full-time faculty members participating in retirement plans and medical plans. Prior to 2024–25, the survey collected data on the number of full-time faculty members covered (eligible) for such plans, whether or not the faculty members participated in the plans. Analysts should exercise caution when comparing benefits coverage with data collected prior to 2024–25.

form of tuition benefits for dependents of full-time faculty members (see survey report table 10). Roughly 91 percent provided tuition waivers for dependents admitted at the home institution, with 60.4 percent offering full waivers and 30.2 percent offering partial waivers. But the distribution of those benefits varied markedly by institutional control and religious affiliation. Among public institutions, 31.3 percent provided full waivers at the home institution and 50.5 percent provided partial waivers. Among private-independent institutions, 73.4 percent provided full waivers; among religiously affiliated institutions, 88.7 percent did so. Nearly half of all institutions, 46.7 percent, also offered waivers at other specified institutions, often through systems or consortia, and 52.1 percent participated in Tuition Exchange or related competitive programs. These arrangements were much more common at private institutions than at public ones.

One additional detail underscores how benefits are structured rather than simply granted: 41.6 percent of institutions reported that eligibility for dependent tuition benefits is limited to faculty meeting certain requirements, such as a particular number of years in service. Public institutions were far less likely than private ones to impose such requirements. In other words, benefits are not merely "offered" or "not offered." Their actual value depends on institutional rules, timing, and whether a faculty member remains employed long enough to qualify fully.

Administrator Salaries

The 2025–26 survey confirms that administrator compensation remains far above faculty compensation; the symbolic and material gap between faculty members and executives continues to grow. Median presidential salaries ranged from about $275,000 at public associate's institutions without ranking systems to $850,000 at private-independent doctoral universities. In public doctoral institutions, the median was $651,084; in religiously affiliated doctoral institutions, it was $837,517 (see survey report table 11). Chief academic officer salaries ranged from $178,980 in public associate's institutions without ranks to $528,379 in religiously affiliated doctoral institutions (see survey report table 13). Chief financial officer salaries ranged from $156,850 in associate's institutions without ranks to above $450,000 in religiously affiliated doctoral institutions (see survey report table 14).

The ratio of presidential salary to full professor salary remains especially revealing. In public baccalaureate institutions, the median presidential-to-professor ratio was just over three to one. In private-independent doctoral institutions it was 5.44, and in religiously affiliated doctoral institutions it was 5.27 (see survey report table 12). These are significant differences that reflect the value that institutions place on different kinds of work; the ratio in doctoral institutions has been rising for decades.

Part-Time Faculty Compensation

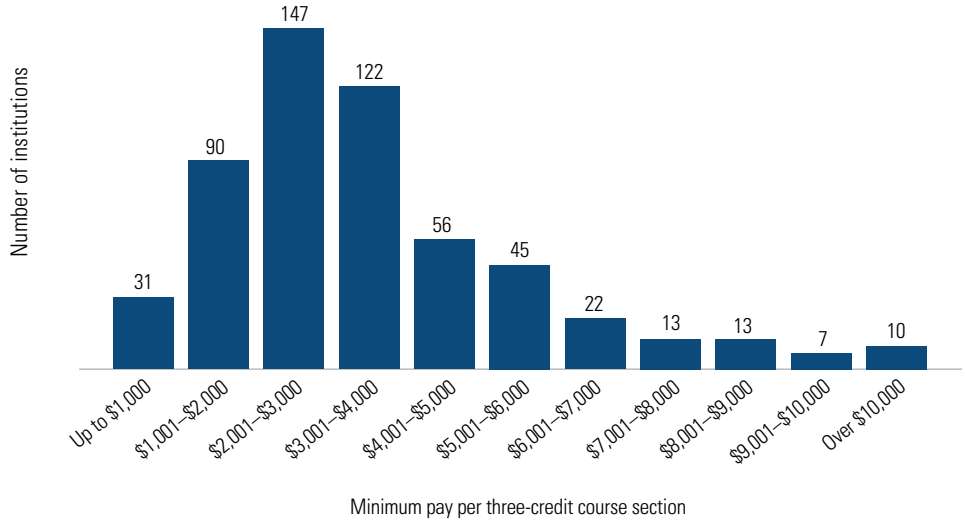
In 2025–26, 664 institutions provided at least some data on part-time faculty members, a 55 percent increase from last year, when 406 institutions provided such data. The increase was due in large part to the fact that this year the survey began requiring all institutions to report minimum pay for part-time faculty members who are paid per course section, if applicable. Though institutions have in the past indicated that reporting part-time faculty pay is difficult, minimum rates are often easy to determine from institutional policy documents such as collective bargaining agreements and faculty handbooks. Among 428 institutions reporting both average pay and the number of part-time faculty members paid per course section,[11] average pay in academic year 2024–25 was $4,093 for a standard three-credit course section (see survey report table 15). That was unchanged in nominal terms from the prior year, which means it declined in real (inflation-adjusted) terms. Average pay per course section also varied widely by institutional type, from $3,200 in religiously affiliated master's institutions to $6,320 in private-independent baccalaureate institutions. Minimum and maximum rates spanned very large ranges, with minima under $1,000 and maxima above $30,000 in highly specialized cases.

How to interpret part-time faculty compensation
Data on part-time pay per course section are collected for the prior academic year and apply to faculty members paid on a per-course-section basis for standard credit-bearing undergraduate instruction; individualized instruction and noncredit teaching arrangements are excluded.

11. This figure represents the number of institutions that reported pay amounts and excludes 70 institutions that reported employing no part-time faculty members on a per-course-section basis and 166 that reported only the number of part-time faculty members or their benefits coverage.

FIGURE 3

Minimum pay per three-credit course section was $4,000 or less at the majority of institutions (70%) in 2024–25.



Note: This figure presents the distribution of minimum pay per three-credit course section across all responding institutions ($n = 556$) in 2024–25.
Source: AAUP Faculty Compensation Survey.

The expanded emphasis on minimum-pay reporting was especially informative. This year, 556 institutions reported minimum pay per course section, compared with 339 the year before, while 70 institutions reported that they do not hire part-time faculty on a per-course-section basis. Among the institutions reporting minimum pay for a standard three-credit section, the median was $3,130, and nearly one-fifth reported minimum pay above $5,000 (see figure 3). Minimum pay was lower at associate's institutions than at four-year institutions and lower in religiously affiliated four-year institutions than in private-independent ones.

Benefits for part-time faculty members paid per course section remained sparse. About 32.7 percent of institutions contributed toward retirement plans for some or all of such faculty members, and 30.6 percent contributed toward medical insurance premiums. Associate's institutions were the most likely to contribute to both kinds of benefits, with 53.8 percent reporting retirement contributions and 48.9 percent reporting medical contributions (see survey report table 16).

The Academic Workforce

Employment figures from the BLS Employment, Hours, and Earnings series should be read with care, because they represent head count—the number of jobs reported on payroll—rather than full-time equivalent (FTE) employment. By early 2025, the number of employees (head count) in public colleges and universities had finally recovered to or slightly surpassed prepandemic levels, while employment in private institutions remained below where it was in February 2020, just before the World Health Organization officially declared the COVID-19 outbreak a pandemic. However, from January 2025 through February 2026, total higher education employment fell about 1.9 percent, including a 1.5 percent decline among public institutions and a 2.4 percent decline among private institutions (see figure 4). Because these data count jobs rather than total labor capacity, an apparent increase can be misleading: For example, a campus could eliminate 100 full-time positions and replace them with 150 part-time jobs, and the BLS series would show employment growth even though total FTE employment had actually fallen. Even with that caveat, the pattern remains clear enough: Recovery has been partial, fragile, and uneven, especially in the private sector.

FIGURE 4

By early 2025, employment in colleges and universities had nearly recovered to or slightly surpassed prepandemic levels of early 2020, but it has since fallen by 1.9 percent.



Note: This figure presents seasonally adjusted employment in colleges and universities by institutional control from January 2000 through February 2026. Figures include all persons who worked or received pay for any part of the pay period that includes the twelfth day of the month: full-time and part-time employees, faculty and staff, and those on paid leave. Figures represent head count (number of jobs), not full-time equivalent employment. For each data series, the first three labeled values represent employment when recessions started and include March 2001, December 2007, and February 2020, when the COVID-19 recession began; the last two labeled values represent employment at its overall peak, in January 2025, and at the most recent point, in February 2026.

Source: US Bureau of Labor Statistics, Employment, Hours, and Earnings from the Current Employment Statistics survey (National), Series IDs CES6561130001 (privately owned colleges and universities) and CES9092161101 (publicly owned postsecondary schools), retrieved from https://download.bls.gov/pub/time.series/ce/ce.data.65a.EducationAndHealthCare.Employment and https://fred.stlouisfed.org/series/CES9092161101 on April 4, 2026.

Student Enrollment Patterns

Student enrollment, which is directly tied to higher education employment, rose for the third consecutive year after four straight years of declines following the COVID-19 pandemic, but not in a way that lifted all institutions equally. The National Student Clearinghouse reported that fall 2025 postsecondary enrollment exceeded 19.4 million students, up 1.0 percent over fall 2024, with most of the growth occurring in undergraduate education and especially in community colleges and public four-year institutions.[12] Certificate programs and dual enrollment were major drivers of that gain. This is encouraging news, but it does not mean that institutions have returned to the old financial equilibrium. Growth concentrated in shorter-term credentials and in community colleges will not resolve the pressures facing tuition-dependent private, smaller regional, or research institutions coping with unstable federal funding. In short, the enrollment recovery has been real, but it has not been uniform.

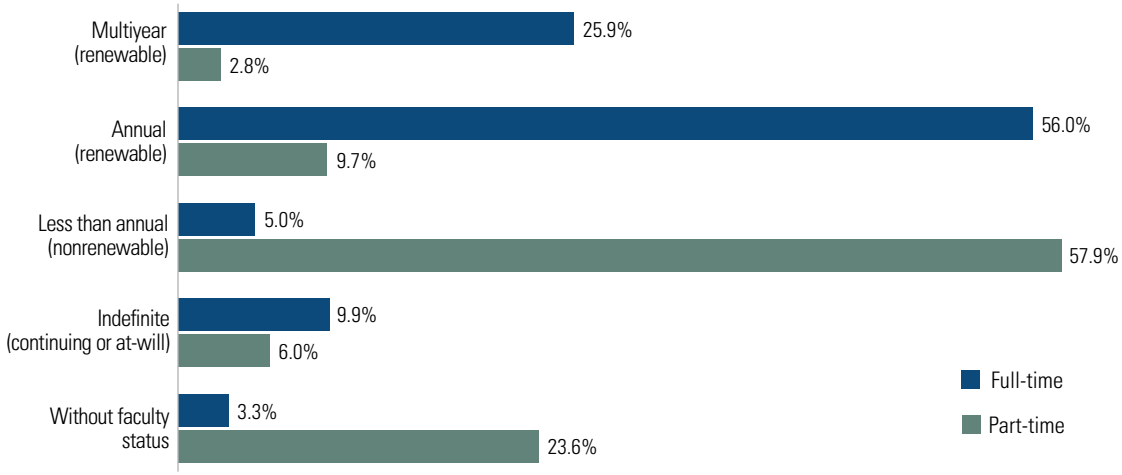
Tenure and Contingency

The long shift away from tenure remains the defining structural fact of the profession. The AAUP's *Data Snapshot: Tenure and Contingency in US Higher Education, Fall 2023* reported that only 31.8 percent of faculty members in US colleges and universities held full-time tenured or tenure-track appointments in fall 2023, compared with 53.1 percent in fall 1987. Conversely, 68.2 percent held either part-time or full-time contingent appointments, compared with 46.9 percent in 1987. Nearly half of all faculty members held part-time contingent appointments. This is a

12. National Student Clearinghouse, "Fall Undergraduate Enrollment Shows Overall Growth Despite Decline at Private Colleges," news release, January 15, 2026, https://www.studentclearinghouse.org/news/fall-undergraduate-enrollment-shows-overall-growth-despite-decline-at-private-colleges/.

FIGURE 5

Most full-time contingent faculty members are on renewable contracts, while most part-time contingent faculty members are on nonrenewable less-than-annual contracts.



Note: This figure presents the percentage of the total number of faculty members on contingent appointments by employment status and contract type in fall 2024. Figures represent nonmedical instructional staff (instruction, research, public service, or primarily instruction), with or without formal faculty status, in degree-granting nonprofit institutions participating in Title IV federal financial-aid programs in the United States (fifty states and the District of Columbia). The term contingent refers to appointments that are ineligible for tenure, including non-tenure-track appointments and appointments at institutions without tenure systems. Percentages may not sum to 100 because of rounding.

Source: IPEDS Human Resources survey component (Fall Staff) 2024–25 provisional release. Data retrieved and compiled by the AAUP Department of Research and Public Policy on January 8, 2026.

transformation of the labor system, not a marginal adjustment.

Contract structure helps make that transformation more concrete. Among part-time contingent faculty members in fall 2024, 81.5 percent either held short-term nonrenewable contracts or lacked formal faculty status altogether (see figure 5). Full-time non-tenure-track faculty are commonly employed on annual contracts, while part-time faculty often work on one- or two-term arrangements. In practical terms, a large share of faculty members hold appointments too brief or too precarious to have either academic freedom or long-term economic security.

Graduate Student Employees and Medical Schools

Graduate student employees have also become more central to the academic labor system. The AAUP's *Data Snapshot: Tenure and Contingency in US Higher Education, Fall 2023* indicates that their numbers grew markedly from the early 2000s through 2023, even as their employment dipped during the COVID-19 pandemic and then recovered. In many institutions they are no longer peripheral to instruction. They are an integral part of the labor architecture through which undergraduate education is delivered.

Medical schools remain a special case because they are especially dependent on grant funding and rely heavily on a contingent faculty workforce. The AAUP's *Data Snapshot: Tenure and Contingency in US Medical Schools, Fall 2023*, shows that only about a quarter of instructional faculty in US medical schools held full-time tenured or tenure-track appointments in fall 2023, while contingent appointments dominated these institutions. In a period of unstable research funding, that structure leaves academic medicine especially exposed to the interaction of federal policy and academic employment insecurity.

Methodological Issues

Because the Faculty Compensation Survey is so often used for benchmarking, bargaining, and public argument, it is important to be explicit about what the

data can show clearly and where they require caution. The methodological cautions in this section are not incidental qualifications; they are an essential part of the report's main argument.

The AAUP Faculty Compensation Survey was created not only to describe faculty pay but also to make salary structures legible enough for institutions to compare themselves to peers and, where necessary, to act. Its purpose was benchmarking and adjustment, not passive recordkeeping. The 1958–59 *Report of Committee Z on the Economic Status of the Profession* stated that the survey was intended to create "additional incentives" for needed salary adjustments and to reveal whether an institution's salary scale was unduly low relative to that of comparable institutions. That historical statement is the best short description of the survey's continued purpose. It is a benchmarking instrument, an accountability device, and a tool for practical salary judgments—not merely a record of annual change.

Voluntary Participation and Nonprobability Sampling

Participation in the Faculty Compensation Survey is voluntary; the survey is neither a census nor a probability sample of the full universe of US institutions. Its value rests on continuity, scale, relevance, and institutional recognizability, not on random sampling. This limitation does not invalidate the results. It does mean, however, that the survey should be interpreted as a powerful professional resource rather than as a perfectly representative national statistical system. It also explains why the AAUP often supplements the survey with IPEDS, BLS, State Higher Education Executive Officers Association (SHEEO), and National Student Clearinghouse data when it moves from compensation tables to broader claims about the profession.

Why Averages Can Mislead

The survey reports averages (arithmetic means, weighted by the number of faculty members), not medians, for most compensation tables. That choice is practical: Median reporting would impose a much heavier burden on institutions. But means can be pulled upward by high-salary outliers or changed by shifts in institutional composition. This is why the survey excludes "faculty whose base salary falls well outside the norm for a particular rank." This is also why survey report table 5, with its percentile distributions of institutions, is so important. It answers a different and often more useful question: not simply what the average salary is but where an institution stands relative to others.

The Importance of Continuing Faculty Comparisons

The difference between all-faculty averages and continuing faculty comparisons is one of the most important factors to consider when interpreting the survey results. Overall averages are essential for revealing long-term trends, but they can rise or fall because institutions hire, lose, or promote faculty members or restructure their positions. Continuing faculty averages remove much of that compositional noise and show what happens to the salaries of those who remain in the profession. This is why the continuing faculty series often gives a better picture of actual raises than the all-faculty average does. In a year like 2025–26, when composition clearly mattered, the distinction becomes indispensable.

Why the AAUP Uses the CPI-U

The AAUP has long reported salary change in both nominal and real terms, and that practice remains essential. This report continues to use the CPI-U because it provides a long, familiar, publicly legible series for salary analysis and because the Association's annual reports have historically relied on the CPI-U and its retroactive series for long-run comparisons. Other inflation indices serve other purposes. For an annual report centered on faculty purchasing power, the CPI-U remains the most sensible standard.

Methodological Reminders

The Explanation of Statistical Data section presented at the end of this report defines the methodologies, definitions, and categories used in the survey and reported in the results. To further ensure consistent interpretation of compensation data across institutions, here are a few brief methodological reminders:

- Participation rates fluctuate every year because institutions differ in staffing, systems, and reporting capacity. In 2025–26, those routine problems were likely intensified by new federal admissions-data burdens.
- Part-time faculty data are collected for the prior academic year to ensure that they represent a full academic year for each institution; they are not nationally representative.
- Benefit coverage (eligibility) and benefit participation are not the same thing. Because the survey

began separating those concepts more explicitly in 2024–25, analysts should exercise caution when comparing benefits over time.
- IPEDS reporting structures still constrain gender reporting, which limits what the AAUP can say nationally about nonbinary faculty members.
- Average salaries and proportions of faculty with tenure can rise for reasons that have nothing to do with genuine increases in salary or in the ranks of tenured faculty, such as reductions in lower-paid contingent faculty positions.
- Average pay-per-course-section figures can misrepresent precarity because part-time instructional employment is fragmented and unstable.

Conclusion and Policy Implications

The findings of the 2025–26 survey point to a profession still living in the long shadow of compensation erosion. Faculty salaries rose, but not as much as inflation. Continuing faculty recovered a little ground, but not much. Salary inequity persisted. Benefits remained uneven. Part-time faculty compensation remained indefensibly low. Administrator compensation continued to far outpace faculty pay. And all of this unfolded in a labor system where tenure-line appointments remain the minority condition. These are not isolated statistics. Together, they describe a profession whose economic status remains fragile even as the most visible indicators have improved slightly.

Faculty compensation is often discussed as if it were mainly a local payroll matter. It is not. It is shaped by the larger political economy of higher education—by public funding, enrollment change, endowment inequality, noninstructional cost growth, debt, and institutional distress. The latest SHEEO reporting shows that, in 2026, state and local funding for higher education hit a record high total, after adjusting for inflation but not student enrollment, while inflation-adjusted per-student spending fell for the first time since 2012. Total postsecondary enrollment increased 1.0 percent in fall 2025, according to National Student Clearinghouse data, but most of the growth occurred in community colleges (+3.0 percent), public four-year institutions (+1.4 percent), certificate programs (+1.9 percent), and dual-enrollment settings (+3.0 percent).[13] The 2024–25 AAUP annual report showed that more than half of all private-sector endowment assets were held by a handful of institutions; this concentration means that some private institutions have the reserves to cushion shocks and invest strategically, while others have little margin for error. The 2024–25 report also showed that large numbers of institutions carried debt-to-assets ratios above 1.0, meaning that their debt exceeded the value of their endowment assets; this situation can become constraining in a sector already facing slower revenue growth, demographic pressure, and volatility.

This context helps explain why closures, mergers, layoffs, and financial emergencies have remained a persistent feature of the landscape. Ratings-agency outlooks all point in the same direction: Higher education remains fiscally divided between institutions with substantial buffers and those living close to the edge. The credit-rating agencies Moody's, Fitch, and S&P have all warned that slower revenue growth, persistent cost growth, demographic pressures, and federal policy volatility will continue to weaken margins, especially for smaller and more tuition-dependent institutions.

It is tempting for some to blame faculty compensation for higher education's cost pressures. After all, real core expenses, including faculty salary expenditures, have sometimes risen faster than real core revenue. But as documented in the 2023–24 annual report, noninstructional expenditures, such as administrator salaries, have often grown faster than instructional expenditures. Colleges and universities are not under strain primarily because they pay faculty members too much. They are under strain because revenue is uneven, federal and state support is volatile, benefits and debt service are expensive, and noninstructional spending has been growing rapidly.

The policy implications extend beyond salary alone because, as the AAUP has long recognized, faculty compensation is tied to tenure, academic freedom, and shared governance. The joint 1940 *Statement of Principles on Academic Freedom and Tenure* of the AAUP and the American Association of Colleges and Universities remains the foundational document for academic freedom and tenure in US higher education and serves as the basis for policies in most institutions with tenure systems. As it famously declares, tenure is a means not only to academic freedom but also to "a sufficient degree of economic security to make the profession attractive to men and women of ability." Further, "freedom and economic security, hence, tenure, are indispensable to the success of an institution

13. State Higher Education Executive Officers Association, *State Higher Education Finance FY 2025*, https://shef.sheeo.org/wp-content/uploads/2026/04/SHEF_FY25_Report.pdf.

in fulfilling its obligations to its students and to society." A profession cannot become predominantly contingent without changing the terms on which teaching and research are carried out. Institutions cannot widen the gap between faculty and administrator compensation indefinitely without also changing how authority is distributed. And college and university administrations cannot ask the faculty to share responsibility for institutional direction while withholding the financial and employment data necessary to make that responsibility real.[14]

The profession's economic condition is also inseparable from student learning conditions. When colleges and universities rely heavily on precarious, low-paid, and benefits-poor instructional labor, they are not merely economizing. They are altering the conditions under which teaching, advising, and mentoring take place. Faculty working conditions are student learning conditions because the quality and continuity of academic work depend on the people who do it—and on the terms under which they do it.

Finally, a profession cannot govern itself effectively if it cannot see itself clearly. Nor can a college or university credibly claim commitments to academic freedom, shared governance, or transparency and equity while treating compensation data as proprietary information. Such commitments demand more than limited administrative disclosure on a need-to-know basis. Annual, reliable, disaggregated data on employment, salary, benefits, and working conditions should be made available to the faculty. As discussed in *The Role of the Faculty in Budgetary and Salary Matters*, both the criteria for salary raises and the recommendatory procedures themselves need to be "(a) designed by a representative group of the faculty in concert with the administration and (b) open and clearly understood."

Accessing the Data

Detailed institution-level listings are published as separate appendixes to this report and are available on the AAUP website at https://www.aaup.org/FCS. AAUP chapter officers, AAUP state conference officers, and AFT local officers may order full datasets free of charge, and institutions may purchase data products for a fee at https://research.aaup.org/order. Results may also be explored on the AAUP's interactive data website at https://data.aaup.org/, which includes institution-level tools for summarizing data by region, state, institutional size, Carnegie Basic Classification, and other variables.

Acknowledgments

The AAUP Faculty Compensation Survey depends on the work of institutional research, human resources, academic affairs, and finance professionals across hundreds of colleges and universities. Their reporting labor makes national compensation analysis possible. This work rests not only on faculty concern but also on the diligence of staff who compile and verify the institutional data underlying the tables and appendixes. We also acknowledge the contribution of the National Higher Education Benchmarking Institute (NHEBI) in developing and supporting the Faculty Compensation Survey data submission portal. NHEBI, established in 2004, is a nonprofit service and research institute sponsored and supported by Johnson County Community College (Kansas). ■

This report was authored by Glenn T. Colby, senior researcher at the AAUP, and is published under the auspices of the AAUP's Committee on the Economic Status of the Profession.

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14. See the AAUP's 1972 statement *The Role of the Faculty in Budgetary and Salary Matters* for Association-recommended principles and standards regarding the faculty's appropriate role in budgetary and salary decisions.

SURVEY REPORT TABLE 1

Average full-time faculty salary, by AAUP category, affiliation, and academic rank, 2025–26 (dollars)

Academic rank	All combined	Public	Private-independent	Religiously affiliated
AAUP CATEGORY I (Doctoral)				
Professor	184,361	168,759	237,467	178,712
Associate	122,300	117,478	143,951	122,928
Assistant	105,052	100,452	125,261	107,979
Instructor	78,051	73,104	91,906	95,273
Lecturer	87,644	82,079	105,117	82,382
No rank	81,884	81,128	92,362	97,571
All combined	131,678	122,691	166,750	130,990
AAUP CATEGORY IIA (Master's)				
Professor	120,105	118,788	130,017	116,611
Associate	98,805	99,198	103,244	93,981
Assistant	84,212	84,490	87,874	80,981
Instructor	67,455	64,993	74,647	70,962
Lecturer	74,214	73,039	86,083	67,296
No rank	69,442	66,709	73,798	70,182
All combined	96,817	96,105	103,809	93,548
AAUP CATEGORY IIB (Baccalaureate)				
Professor	124,681	113,046	140,588	101,222
Associate	96,141	92,970	105,292	83,057
Assistant	81,819	78,446	89,176	72,530
Instructor	69,777	73,421	72,737	61,395
Lecturer	79,492	71,632	88,257	67,247
No rank	86,470	58,188	92,440	72,497
All combined	97,924	89,279	109,481	83,497
AAUP CATEGORY III (Associate's with ranks)				
Professor	110,739	110,739	n.d.	n.d.
Associate	89,396	89,396	n.d.	n.d.
Assistant	74,037	74,037	n.d.	n.d.
Instructor	63,155	63,155	n.d.	n.d.
Lecturer	85,858	85,858	n.d.	n.d.
No rank	72,786	72,786	n.d.	n.d.
All combined	89,692	89,692	n.d.	n.d.
AAUP CATEGORY IV (Associate's without ranks)				
No rank	91,802	91,802	n.d.	n.d.
ALL AAUP CATEGORIES COMBINED EXCEPT IV				
Professor	163,836	154,341	205,034	138,469
Associate	113,427	111,594	127,004	102,905
Assistant	97,232	95,577	109,769	87,260
Instructor	74,087	70,621	84,804	78,423
Lecturer	84,292	79,625	101,715	77,956
No rank	78,520	78,266	78,981	80,427
All combined	119,836	114,703	145,148	105,925

Note: The table is based on 768 institutions reporting full-time faculty salary data. For definitions of categories, see Explanation of Statistical Data. There were no private-independent or religiously affiliated institutions in categories III or IV. N.d. = no data.

SURVEY REPORT TABLE 2

Annual percentage change in average salary for full-time faculty and continuing faculty, by AAUP category, affiliation, and academic rank, 2024–25 to 2025–26

	All faculty				Continuing faculty			
Academic rank	All combined	Public	Private-independent	Religiously affiliated	All combined	Public	Private-independent	Religiously affiliated
AAUP CATEGORY I (Doctoral)								
Professor	1.7	2.0	0.8	1.3	2.8	3.0	2.3	2.4
Associate	2.2	2.5	1.0	2.0	3.8	3.9	3.4	3.3
Assistant	1.8	2.0	0.9	2.6	3.8	3.8	3.2	4.6
Instructor	3.7	3.9	2.2	4.3	3.8	4.1	2.6	3.7
Lecturer	3.5	4.4	1.4	5.5	3.7	3.9	3.1	3.6
No rank	3.2	2.6	25.9	7.1	3.7	3.7	4.8	5.7
All combined	2.2	2.5	1.3	2.2	3.3	3.5	2.7	3.2
AAUP CATEGORY IIA (Master's)								
Professor	1.4	1.2	2.1	1.9	2.9	2.8	3.6	2.5
Associate	2.2	1.8	3.7	2.0	3.5	3.6	3.8	3.0
Assistant	1.5	1.0	3.1	1.5	3.4	3.3	4.1	3.1
Instructor	2.0	3.2	–1.7	3.1	3.6	3.4	3.9	4.0
Lecturer	3.8	3.8	4.4	2.4	3.4	3.3	4.2	2.7
No rank	0.0	–2.0	–2.3	0.6	3.7	3.7	5.3	–1.0
All combined	2.1	2.0	2.9	1.9	3.2	3.2	3.8	2.9
AAUP CATEGORY IIB (Baccalaureate)								
Professor	2.2	4.4	1.0	1.6	3.2	4.0	3.2	2.9
Associate	2.6	3.5	0.8	2.8	4.1	5.0	4.1	3.6
Assistant	3.0	3.3	2.0	2.9	4.4	5.2	4.4	4.0
Instructor	2.6	3.9	2.4	1.0	4.4	4.6	4.9	3.6
Lecturer	5.1	5.8	3.9	7.4	5.2	5.7	5.1	3.8
No rank	0.1	3.0	1.4	2.0	3.0	2.1	2.7	4.7
All combined	3.1	4.4	1.9	2.6	3.9	4.7	3.8	3.4
AAUP CATEGORY III (Associate's with ranks)								
Professor	4.9	4.9	n.d.	n.d.	5.7	5.7	n.d.	n.d.
Associate	3.4	3.4	n.d.	n.d.	6.3	6.3	n.d.	n.d.
Assistant	2.3	2.3	n.d.	n.d.	6.7	6.7	n.d.	n.d.
Instructor	2.2	2.2	n.d.	n.d.	5.7	5.7	n.d.	n.d.
Lecturer	8.5	8.5	n.d.	n.d.	9.5	9.5	n.d.	n.d.
No rank	–1.5	–1.5	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.
All combined	4.2	4.2	n.d.	n.d.	6.3	6.3	n.d.	n.d.
AAUP CATEGORY IV (Associate's without ranks)								
No rank	1.6	1.6	n.d.	n.d.	1.9	1.9	n.d.	n.d.
ALL AAUP CATEGORIES COMBINED EXCEPT IV								
Professor	1.6	1.8	0.8	1.9	2.9	3.1	2.6	2.6
Associate	2.3	2.5	1.4	2.4	3.8	3.9	3.6	3.2
Assistant	1.8	1.9	1.1	2.1	3.8	3.8	3.6	3.7
Instructor	3.2	3.5	2.6	4.2	3.9	4.0	3.3	3.8
Lecturer	3.8	4.5	1.8	5.0	3.8	3.9	3.4	3.4
No rank	1.8	1.9	–3.2	5.5	3.7	3.7	4.9	1.5
All combined	2.3	2.4	1.5	2.5	3.4	3.5	3.1	3.1

Note: The table is based on 752 institutions reporting full-time faculty salary data in both 2024–25 and 2025–26 and 699 institutions reporting full-time continuing faculty salary data in 2025–26. Figures for continuing faculty represent the annual percentage change in average salary, in nominal terms, for faculty employed at the same institution in both years and exclude salaries for new hires and departed faculty. For definitions of categories, see Explanation of Statistical Data. There were no private-independent or religiously affiliated institutions in categories III or IV. Rows labeled "All combined" include lecturers and unranked faculty where reported. N.d. = no data.

SURVEY REPORT TABLE 3

Average salary for men and women full-time faculty, by affiliation, AAUP category, and academic rank, 2025–26 (dollars)

	All combined		Public		Private-independent		Religiously affiliated	
Academic rank	Men	Women	Men	Women	Men	Women	Men	Women
AAUP CATEGORY I (Doctoral)								
Professor	191,873	170,202	175,136	156,893	247,373	217,197	184,131	169,856
Associate	126,632	117,428	121,546	112,867	149,741	137,398	126,688	119,081
Assistant	110,054	100,595	105,025	96,370	132,091	118,999	112,640	104,264
Instructor	81,807	75,091	76,199	70,788	95,346	88,592	100,647	90,821
Lecturer	92,275	83,783	86,475	78,397	110,969	100,207	83,870	81,257
No rank	85,366	79,037	84,287	78,525	107,413	70,862	108,805	90,830
All combined	143,430	117,765	132,931	110,695	183,511	145,396	140,450	120,887
AAUP CATEGORY IIA (Master's)								
Professor	122,452	117,038	120,645	116,355	134,810	124,328	119,316	112,816
Associate	100,533	97,120	100,796	97,596	105,442	101,177	95,651	92,437
Assistant	85,967	82,937	86,022	83,290	89,416	86,841	83,343	79,475
Instructor	69,172	66,350	66,221	64,224	77,260	72,671	73,076	69,605
Lecturer	75,400	73,330	73,743	72,515	90,551	82,619	67,980	66,820
No rank	71,714	67,614	70,590	63,281	74,790	73,075	69,142	70,892
All combined	101,041	92,854	99,960	92,396	109,006	99,153	98,401	89,215
AAUP CATEGORY IIB (Baccalaureate)								
Professor	126,566	122,296	114,990	110,514	142,498	138,174	102,993	99,007
Associate	97,461	94,858	93,985	91,915	107,195	103,528	84,298	81,805
Assistant	82,141	81,571	80,534	76,592	89,368	89,029	71,956	72,947
Instructor	70,949	68,917	74,193	72,912	74,097	71,639	62,434	60,661
Lecturer	78,981	79,852	74,106	69,498	86,072	89,600	66,581	67,628
No rank	89,129	84,202	n.d.	58,188	88,118	97,981	95,450	65,939
All combined	101,256	94,750	92,478	86,175	113,265	105,870	86,061	81,089
AAUP CATEGORY III (Associate's with ranks)								
Professor	113,010	108,895	113,010	108,895	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.
Associate	90,196	88,691	90,196	88,691	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.
Assistant	74,432	73,728	74,432	73,728	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.
Instructor	62,832	63,358	62,832	63,358	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.
Lecturer	88,060	84,173	88,060	84,173	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.
No rank	72,786	n.d.	72,786	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.
All combined	91,339	88,377	91,339	88,377	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.
AAUP CATEGORY IV (Associate's without ranks)								
No rank	92,429	91,260	92,429	91,260	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.
ALL AAUP CATEGORIES COMBINED EXCEPT IV								
Professor	172,101	150,245	161,324	142,832	217,388	183,706	143,474	131,177
Associate	117,249	109,355	115,230	107,639	132,200	121,584	105,528	100,344
Assistant	101,520	93,652	99,556	92,143	115,516	105,020	90,311	85,121
Instructor	77,261	71,742	73,214	68,786	88,152	81,824	82,453	75,513
Lecturer	88,152	81,175	83,129	76,782	107,193	97,250	79,373	76,921
No rank	81,649	75,967	81,488	75,574	80,430	77,737	86,431	76,979
All combined	130,064	108,678	123,787	104,719	160,055	128,239	112,961	99,135

Note: The table is based on 768 institutions reporting full-time faculty salary data. For definitions of categories, see Explanation of Statistical Data. There were no private-independent or religiously affiliated institutions in categories III or IV. N.d. = no data.

SURVEY REPORT TABLE 4

Average salary for full-time faculty, by region, AAUP category, and academic rank, 2025–26 (dollars)

Academic rank	Northeast		North Central		South			West	
	New England[a]	Middle Atlantic[b]	East North Central[c]	West North Central[d]	East South Central[e]	West South Central[f]	South Atlantic[g]	Mountain[h]	Pacific[i]
AAUP CATEGORY I (Doctoral)									
Professor	227,106	211,599	172,092	152,373	145,970	170,856	172,758	152,308	217,756
Associate	139,278	133,966	118,731	107,747	104,114	115,709	120,332	112,325	140,874
Assistant	122,646	114,706	104,360	93,638	88,987	101,424	102,764	92,862	121,321
Instructor	102,306	85,318	73,261	67,857	65,406	79,407	77,066	74,250	84,685
Lecturer	101,852	106,436	78,484	71,255	71,123	81,188	79,901	76,240	108,524
No rank	108,827	80,714	75,390	67,815	85,408	57,481	91,796	88,914	92,767
All combined	161,819	148,982	126,498	113,700	104,057	118,417	125,385	111,910	162,939
AAUP CATEGORY IIA (Master's)									
Professor	140,589	133,734	100,696	95,239	102,583	101,317	113,197	104,071	133,448
Associate	110,706	107,364	87,440	80,373	84,854	85,892	92,691	89,451	113,086
Assistant	94,697	87,987	78,570	70,529	75,465	75,068	80,981	74,572	97,671
Instructor	82,494	71,214	63,495	63,126	61,510	60,850	68,534	55,462	74,567
Lecturer	91,810	90,332	59,236	61,281	61,110	59,925	63,905	70,955	82,972
No rank	69,518	75,938	62,702	178,190	71,482	55,846	69,355	62,736	104,252
All combined	111,882	107,559	84,298	78,157	82,767	81,268	90,409	83,846	111,756
AAUP CATEGORY IIB (Baccalaureate)									
Professor	146,049	138,696	102,487	108,667	103,698	85,274	111,652	112,620	155,951
Associate	111,461	105,735	84,874	83,521	85,255	74,783	85,032	95,917	121,537
Assistant	95,136	89,203	72,566	71,627	69,388	67,741	78,392	80,505	100,532
Instructor	73,186	77,112	60,018	64,166	63,053	54,562	65,116	65,454	79,403
Lecturer	92,750	86,441	61,728	76,542	58,687	56,171	66,676	58,955	78,978
No rank	105,984	85,557	72,370	75,565	40,000	70,719	158,030	65,529	69,000
All combined	115,013	107,015	84,566	85,938	84,515	73,612	86,812	91,276	125,273
AAUP CATEGORY III (Associate's with ranks)									
Professor	92,324	128,998	96,832	90,643	76,643	106,977	108,117	96,247	114,979
Associate	74,485	110,367	79,418	77,424	66,045	83,588	89,624	78,438	97,143
Assistant	66,550	89,475	64,049	73,937	54,619	73,584	78,895	69,452	86,129
Instructor	50,642	60,601	56,948	69,602	49,426	60,975	65,774	62,148	74,707
Lecturer	n.d.	92,808	63,853	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	55,518	n.d.
No rank	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	72,786	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.
All combined	78,258	109,383	73,599	79,855	62,583	95,341	92,401	76,875	92,768
AAUP CATEGORY IV (Associate's without ranks)									
No rank	59,534	n.d.	93,593	69,575	66,447	65,257	97,547	90,719	123,042
ALL AAUP CATEGORIES COMBINED EXCEPT IV									
Professor	199,311	179,362	152,254	136,945	131,448	153,551	154,642	146,900	183,675
Associate	127,297	121,053	107,715	99,076	97,713	107,954	110,856	108,314	128,304
Assistant	110,543	103,111	93,964	85,526	84,581	95,530	94,873	89,493	110,752
Instructor	92,691	80,519	68,458	65,742	64,096	73,436	73,474	72,998	79,518
Lecturer	99,535	100,741	74,115	69,941	68,001	78,833	75,589	75,331	96,564
No rank	74,908	78,479	72,207	68,647	82,173	57,111	88,147	85,954	96,005
All combined	143,752	130,995	112,796	102,851	97,273	110,302	113,948	107,829	140,603

Note: The table is based on 768 institutions reporting full-time faculty salary data. For definitions of categories, see Explanation of Statistical Data. N.d. = no data.

a. New England: Connecticut, Maine, Massachusetts, New Hampshire, Rhode Island, and Vermont.
b. Middle Atlantic: New Jersey, New York, and Pennsylvania.
c. East North Central: Illinois, Indiana, Michigan, Ohio, and Wisconsin.
d. West North Central: Iowa, Kansas, Minnesota, Missouri, Nebraska, North Dakota, and South Dakota.
e. East South Central: Alabama, Kentucky, Mississippi, and Tennessee.
f. West South Central: Arkansas, Louisiana, Oklahoma, and Texas.
g. South Atlantic: Delaware, District of Columbia, Florida, Georgia, Maryland, North Carolina, Puerto Rico, South Carolina, Virgin Islands, Virginia, and West Virginia.
h. Mountain: Arizona, Colorado, Idaho, Montana, Nevada, New Mexico, Utah, and Wyoming.
i. Pacific: Alaska, California, Guam, Hawaii, Oregon, and Washington.

SURVEY REPORT TABLE 5

Percentile distribution of institutions, by average full-time faculty salary, AAUP category, and academic rank, 2025–26 (dollars)

	Rating[a] and percentile									
	1*		1		2		3		4	
Academic rank	95	90	80	70	60	50	40	30	20	10
AAUP CATEGORY I (Doctoral)										
Professor	277,756	224,406	198,538	179,289	169,300	158,230	147,620	136,939	123,281	111,727
Associate	169,036	155,226	138,930	127,739	122,399	116,733	111,194	104,361	98,717	90,078
Assistant	143,979	133,794	119,972	110,403	105,120	98,837	94,477	90,759	85,659	78,990
Instructor	119,179	106,542	91,539	87,473	81,933	76,891	70,643	66,840	63,180	58,420
Lecturer	117,738	110,397	99,490	91,857	86,411	80,807	75,222	70,329	64,269	58,638
No rank	130,479	122,990	106,294	94,777	77,125	71,068	66,528	64,332	59,355	46,190
All combined	187,366	171,383	147,004	134,710	124,246	117,816	111,202	106,423	97,278	88,332
AAUP CATEGORY IIA (Master's)										
Professor	157,447	144,572	132,794	125,295	115,178	107,647	100,375	94,565	88,293	79,767
Associate	123,714	119,075	109,878	101,526	95,430	89,856	86,487	81,209	76,609	71,017
Assistant	105,008	100,964	93,902	87,613	82,500	78,978	75,937	73,222	70,090	65,163
Instructor	96,751	87,800	80,213	72,783	69,570	65,702	62,987	60,630	57,274	52,800
Lecturer	97,109	92,149	83,816	79,170	71,957	66,406	62,723	59,467	56,198	50,180
No rank	175,175	171,186	111,972	86,014	83,205	72,678	68,119	62,167	57,207	45,474
All combined	125,402	118,308	108,849	100,556	93,008	87,001	83,436	79,608	75,765	69,524
AAUP CATEGORY IIB (Baccalaureate)										
Professor	172,430	160,197	139,567	116,704	106,965	100,926	96,750	88,272	81,909	76,135
Associate	128,337	121,050	107,726	94,899	88,721	85,219	79,618	74,673	69,449	64,930
Assistant	107,779	99,801	88,656	81,135	76,872	73,193	70,201	66,988	63,351	59,423
Instructor	83,115	78,949	74,443	70,009	66,488	64,416	61,351	56,994	53,712	48,357
Lecturer	104,507	102,058	90,156	81,724	73,706	70,710	65,363	62,260	58,462	54,945
No rank	201,089	176,902	104,501	89,411	83,897	70,289	69,000	63,668	61,200	54,657
All combined	134,474	122,640	108,357	94,431	87,692	82,957	78,967	75,510	70,170	64,301
AAUP CATEGORY III (Associate's with ranks)										
Professor	140,840	139,157	123,309	114,664	111,260	101,272	95,562	92,464	89,567	82,765
Associate	117,752	115,177	98,073	94,238	89,856	85,838	80,872	77,725	74,078	69,861
Assistant	99,329	97,142	86,677	83,821	77,203	74,382	70,760	66,684	64,040	62,335
Instructor	78,163	76,616	71,750	70,223	68,700	64,000	60,984	58,866	56,686	55,631
Lecturer	95,426	94,720	93,373	93,326	73,870	69,495	66,769	64,100	60,651	55,518
No rank	72,786	72,786	72,786	72,786	72,786	72,786	72,786	72,786	72,786	72,786
All combined	117,783	113,351	98,568	94,091	88,021	83,269	78,847	78,258	74,285	69,489
AAUP CATEGORY IV (Associate's without ranks)										
No rank	125,973	124,419	121,746	97,384	76,819	70,086	69,037	67,096	62,576	59,534
ALL AAUP CATEGORIES COMBINED EXCEPT IV										
Professor	207,842	180,041	155,023	139,797	126,626	116,427	107,085	98,177	91,390	82,073
Associate	144,110	130,302	119,039	111,046	102,254	95,435	89,022	83,952	78,443	70,932
Assistant	124,669	112,010	101,112	94,477	88,114	82,619	78,019	74,146	69,907	64,065
Instructor	101,844	90,389	82,313	76,350	70,873	67,871	64,303	60,984	57,589	53,040
Lecturer	110,103	100,633	91,974	85,141	79,240	72,604	67,516	62,954	59,072	54,439
No rank	175,175	140,896	104,628	91,878	83,205	71,239	66,547	63,166	59,244	47,330
All combined	150,176	135,654	120,035	110,022	101,742	93,558	86,780	81,951	76,646	70,073

Note: The table is based on 768 institutions reporting full-time faculty salary data. For definitions of categories, see Explanation of Statistical Data. Calculated with the SAS STDIZE procedure using the order statistics method.

[a] Interpretation of the ratings: 1* = 95th percentile; 1 = 80th; 2 = 60th; 3 = 40th; 4 = 20th. An average lower than the 20th percentile is rated 5 (not displayed).

SURVEY REPORT TABLE 6

Percentage of full-time faculty in tenure-track appointments and percentage of faculty with tenure, by affiliation, gender, and academic rank, 2025–26

Academic rank	All combined				Public				Private-independent				Religiously affiliated			
	% T	% TT	% NTT	*N*	% T	% TT	% NTT	*N*	% T	% TT	% NTT	*N*	% T	% TT	% NTT	*N*
MEN																
Professor	92.7	0.6	6.7	72,045	93.8	0.6	5.6	49,339	90.4	0.4	9.2	15,988	90.1	1.1	8.9	6,718
Associate	82.6	5.2	12.2	47,042	84.4	4.2	11.5	32,848	77.4	7.6	14.9	8,723	79.9	7.5	12.6	5,471
Assistant	2.7	72.7	24.6	37,621	2.7	73.8	23.6	26,427	1.1	75.9	23.0	7,038	5.2	60.7	34.1	4,156
Instructor	1.5	2.7	95.8	10,497	0.7	3.5	95.8	7,154	0.2	0.4	99.3	2,035	8.0	1.4	90.6	1,308
Lecturer	3.0	2.0	95.0	17,489	3.9	2.7	93.3	12,870	0.3	0.1	99.7	3,781	0.0	0.0	100.0	838
No rank	19.6	5.4	75.0	2,574	21.8	6.0	72.2	2,317	0.0	0.0	100.0	176	0.0	0.0	100.0	81
All combined	57.6	16.6	25.9	187,268	57.8	16.7	25.4	130,955	56.4	16.1	27.4	37,741	57.9	16.3	25.9	18,572
WOMEN																
Professor	87.2	0.7	12.1	43,808	88.3	0.7	11.0	29,937	86.6	1.4	12.1	4,611	86.6	1.4	12.1	4,611
Associate	76.2	5.0	18.8	44,161	77.7	4.0	18.3	30,195	73.0	7.6	19.4	5,602	73.0	7.6	19.4	5,602
Assistant	2.4	66.2	31.4	45,064	2.5	66.5	31.0	30,617	3.7	57.0	39.3	5,931	3.7	57.0	39.3	5,931
Instructor	1.6	3.3	95.1	14,208	0.9	4.1	95.0	10,110	7.8	1.5	90.7	1,812	7.8	1.5	90.7	1,812
Lecturer	2.5	2.2	95.2	21,654	3.3	3.0	93.6	15,867	0.1	0.0	99.9	1,147	0.1	0.0	99.9	1,147
No rank	15.5	5.6	78.9	3,071	17.4	6.2	76.4	2,725	0.0	0.0	100.0	141	0.0	0.0	100.0	141
All combined	43.2	19.5	37.4	171,966	43.3	19.1	37.6	119,451	43.9	20.3	35.9	19,244	43.9	20.3	35.9	19,244
MEN AND WOMEN COMBINED																
Professor	90.6	0.6	8.7	115,853	91.7	0.6	7.7	79,276	88.1	0.4	11.5	25,248	88.6	1.2	10.2	11,329
Associate	79.5	5.1	15.4	91,203	81.2	4.1	14.7	63,043	75.3	7.3	17.4	17,087	76.4	7.5	16.0	11,073
Assistant	2.5	69.2	28.3	82,685	2.6	69.9	27.6	57,044	1.1	73.5	25.4	15,554	4.3	58.5	37.2	10,087
Instructor	1.6	3.0	95.4	24,705	0.8	3.9	95.3	17,264	0.2	0.7	99.1	4,321	7.9	1.5	90.6	3,120
Lecturer	2.7	2.1	95.1	39,143	3.6	2.9	93.5	28,737	0.4	0.0	99.6	8,421	0.1	n.d.	99.9	1,985
No rank	17.4	5.5	77.1	5,645	19.4	6.1	74.5	5,042	0.8	0.8	98.4	381	n.d.	n.d.	100.0	222
All combined	50.7	18.0	31.4	359,234	50.9	17.9	31.2	250,406	49.7	18.1	32.2	71,012	50.7	18.3	31.0	37,816

Note: The table is based on 768 institutions reporting full-time faculty salary data. Prior to 2003–04, this report counted all faculty who were tenured and in positions leading to consideration for tenure as tenure-track faculty and did not separately report faculty not on the tenure track. Two institutions were excluded because they did not report salary data for non-tenure-track faculty. T = tenured, TT = tenure-track, NTT = non-tenure-track, n.d. = no data. Percentages may not sum to 100 because of rounding.

SURVEY REPORT TABLE 7

Percentage of full-time faculty, by affiliation, gender, AAUP category, and rank, 2025–26

	All combined				Public				Private-independent				Religiously affiliated			
Academic rank	Men	Women	*N*	% of total	Men	Women	*N*	% of total	Men	Women	*N*	% of total	Men	Women	*N*	% of total
AAUP CATEGORY I (Doctoral)																
Professor	65.3	34.7	78,789	33.3	65.0	35.0	57,021	32.3	67.2	32.8	17,235	37.8	62.0	38.0	4,533	31.5
Associate	52.9	47.1	58,569	24.7	53.1	46.9	44,567	25.2	53.1	46.9	9,804	21.5	50.6	49.4	4,198	29.1
Assistant	47.1	52.9	53,451	22.6	47.2	52.8	41,452	23.5	47.8	52.2	9,002	19.8	44.3	55.7	2,997	20.8
Instructor	44.1	55.9	15,412	6.5	42.8	57.2	11,571	6.5	49.1	50.9	2,647	5.8	45.3	54.7	1,194	8.3
Lecturer	45.5	54.5	28,451	12.0	45.6	54.4	20,194	11.4	45.6	54.4	6,854	15.0	43.1	56.9	1,403	9.7
No rank	45.0	55.0	1,992	0.8	45.2	54.8	1,895	1.1	58.8	41.2	17	0.0	37.5	62.5	80	0.6
All combined	54.2	45.8	236,664	100.0	53.9	46.1	176,700	100.0	56.0	44.0	45,559	100.0	51.6	48.4	14,405	100.0
AAUP CATEGORY IIA (Master's)																
Professor	56.6	43.4	26,744	30.7	56.7	43.3	18,123	31.7	54.3	45.7	4,026	29.9	58.4	41.6	4,595	28.2
Associate	49.4	50.6	23,388	26.9	50.0	50.0	14,675	25.7	48.5	51.5	3,916	29.1	48.0	52.0	4,797	29.4
Assistant	42.1	57.9	20,878	24.0	43.9	56.1	12,388	21.7	40.1	59.9	3,480	25.9	38.9	61.1	5,010	30.7
Instructor	39.2	60.8	6,089	7.0	38.5	61.5	4,030	7.0	43.1	56.9	734	5.5	39.1	60.9	1,325	8.1
Lecturer	42.7	57.3	9,031	10.4	42.7	57.3	7,522	13.1	43.7	56.3	1,026	7.6	41.0	59.0	483	3.0
No rank	44.6	55.4	848	1.0	46.9	53.1	467	0.8	42.2	57.8	275	2.0	40.6	59.4	106	0.6
All combined	48.4	51.6	86,978	100.0	49.0	51.0	57,205	100.0	47.3	52.7	13,457	100.0	47.2	52.8	16,316	100.0
AAUP CATEGORY IIB (Baccalaureate)																
Professor	55.9	44.1	7,201	30.9	56.6	43.4	1,013	24.1	55.8	44.2	3,987	33.2	55.6	44.4	2,201	31.0
Associate	49.3	50.7	6,589	28.3	51.0	49.0	1,144	27.3	48.1	51.9	3,367	28.1	50.2	49.8	2,078	29.3
Assistant	43.6	56.4	6,124	26.3	47.0	53.0	972	23.2	43.5	56.5	3,072	25.6	42.1	57.9	2,080	29.3
Instructor	42.4	57.6	2,160	9.3	39.7	60.3	619	14.7	44.7	55.3	940	7.8	41.4	58.6	601	8.5
Lecturer	41.3	58.7	1,089	4.7	46.3	53.7	449	10.7	38.1	61.9	541	4.5	36.4	63.6	99	1.4
No rank	46.0	54.0	126	0.5	n.d.	100.0	1	0.0	56.2	43.8	89	0.7	22.2	77.8	36	0.5
All combined	48.8	51.2	23,289	100.0	49.2	50.8	4,198	100.0	48.8	51.2	11,996	100.0	48.4	51.6	7,095	100.0
AAUP CATEGORY III (Associate's with ranks)																
Professor	44.8	55.2	3,119	32.4	44.8	55.2	3,119	32.4	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.
Associate	46.9	53.1	2,657	27.6	46.9	53.1	2,657	27.6	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.
Assistant	43.9	56.1	2,232	23.2	43.9	56.1	2,232	23.2	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.
Instructor	38.6	61.4	1,044	10.8	38.6	61.4	1,044	10.8	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.
Lecturer	43.4	56.6	572	5.9	43.4	56.6	572	5.9	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.
No rank	100.0	0.0	1	0.0	100.0	0.0	1	0.0	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.
All combined	44.4	55.6	9,625	100.0	44.4	55.6	9,625	100.0	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.
AAUP CATEGORY IV (Associate's without ranks)																
No rank	46.3	53.7	2,678	100.0	46.3	53.7	2,678	100.0	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.
AAUP ALL CATEGORIES COMBINED EXCEPT IV																
Professor	62.2	37.8	115,853	32.3	62.2	37.8	79,276	31.7	63.3	36.7	25,248	35.6	59.3	40.7	11,329	30.0
Associate	51.6	48.4	91,203	25.4	52.1	47.9	63,043	25.2	51.1	48.9	17,087	24.1	49.4	50.6	11,073	29.3
Assistant	45.5	54.5	82,685	23.0	46.3	53.7	57,044	22.8	45.2	54.8	15,554	21.9	41.2	58.8	10,087	26.7
Instructor	42.5	57.5	24,767	6.9	41.5	58.5	17,326	6.9	47.1	52.9	4,321	6.1	41.9	58.1	3,120	8.3
Lecturer	44.7	55.3	39,143	10.9	44.8	55.2	28,737	11.5	44.9	55.1	8,421	11.9	42.2	57.8	1,985	5.2
No rank	45.5	54.5	5,583	1.6	45.8	54.2	4,980	2.0	46.2	53.8	381	0.5	36.5	63.5	222	0.6
All combined	52.1	47.9	359,234	100.0	52.3	47.7	250,406	100.0	53.1	46.9	71,012	100.0	49.1	50.9	37,816	100.0

Note: The table is based on 768 institutions reporting full-time faculty salary data. For definitions of categories, see Explanation of Statistical Data. There were no private-independent or religiously affiliated institutions in categories III or IV. N.d. = no data. Percentages may not sum to 100 because of rounding.

SURVEY REPORT TABLE 8

Full-time faculty retirement benefits coverage (eligibility) and participation, by affiliation and AAUP category, 2025–26 (dollars)

	Retirement benefits							
	Coverage (eligibility)				Participation			
Affiliation	Percentage covered	Average contribution ($)	Average salary ($)	Percentage of salary	Percentage participating	Average contribution ($)	Average salary ($)	Percentage of salary
AAUP CATEGORY I (Doctoral)								
Public	98.7	14,768	122,963	12.0	96.5	14,791	122,706	12.1
Private-independent	97.0	14,877	167,038	8.9	95.2	14,830	162,904	9.1
Religiously affiliated	97.6	11,886	130,329	9.1	94.4	11,887	130,329	9.1
All combined	98.3	14,624	131,907	11.1	96.1	14,622	130,198	11.2
AAUP CATEGORY IIA (Master's)								
Public	99.1	12,122	96,682	12.5	98.4	12,188	96,655	12.6
Private-independent	97.5	8,574	103,393	8.3	92.1	8,608	103,491	8.3
Religiously affiliated	98.6	6,217	93,030	6.7	91.5	6,389	93,203	6.9
All combined	98.7	10,521	97,093	10.8	96.2	10,656	97,099	11.0
AAUP CATEGORY IIB (Baccalaureate)								
Public	99.7	12,188	89,172	13.7	99.2	12,572	90,277	13.9
Private-independent	97.4	10,068	109,460	9.2	93.9	10,086	109,716	9.2
Religiously affiliated	97.9	6,365	84,113	7.6	93.5	6,487	84,113	7.7
All combined	98.0	9,315	97,695	9.5	94.7	9,397	98,092	9.6
AAUP CATEGORY III (Associate's with ranks)								
Public	99.7	13,247	90,142	14.7	97.6	13,404	90,149	14.9
AAUP CATEGORY IV (Associate's without ranks)								
Public	98.5	13,774	91,802	15.0	98.3	13,837	92,370	15.0
ALL AAUP CATEGORIES COMBINED EXCEPT IV								
Public	98.8	14,072	115,214	12.2	97.0	14,101	114,941	12.3
Private-independent	97.2	12,920	145,869	8.9	94.4	12,763	141,422	9.0
Religiously affiliated	98.1	8,420	105,577	8.0	93.0	8,563	105,680	8.1
All combined	98.4	13,281	120,132	11.1	96.1	13,293	118,700	11.2

Note: The table is based on 716 reporting institutions. Figures represent institutions that provided retirement benefits data. Coverage represents eligibility regardless of whether the institution contributes to the retirement plan, per Internal Revenue Service guidelines for reporting fringe benefits. Prior to 2024–25, this table reported only coverage (eligibility) and did not separately report participation. Twenty-four institutions did not report participation. The "total compensation" statistic was eliminated in 2019–20 to reduce the number of benefit items to three: retirement, medical, and dependent tuition. Retirement benefits include contributions by the institution, state, and local government to the retirement plan(s) but exclude payments for unfunded retirement liability, prepaid retiree health insurance, and Social Security. There were no private-independent or religiously affiliated institutions in categories III or IV.

SURVEY REPORT TABLE 9

Full-time faculty medical benefits coverage (eligibility) and participation, by affiliation and AAUP category, 2025–26 (dollars)

	Medical benefits							
	Coverage (eligibility)				Participation			
Affiliation	Percentage covered	Average contribution ($)	Average salary ($)	Percentage of salary	Percentage participating	Average contribution ($)	Average salary ($)	Percentage of salary
AAUP CATEGORY I (Doctoral)								
Public	99.0	14,798	122,963	12.0	93.4	14,667	122,329	12.0
Private-independent	98.9	18,226	167,038	10.9	90.5	19,156	162,904	11.8
Religiously affiliated	99.9	15,466	130,329	11.9	86.6	15,816	130,329	12.1
All combined	99.0	15,499	131,907	11.7	92.4	15,515	130,039	11.9
AAUP CATEGORY IIA (Master's)								
Public	98.7	15,299	96,682	15.8	93.9	15,677	96,917	16.2
Private-independent	98.7	13,446	103,187	13.0	83.0	13,948	103,278	13.5
Religiously affiliated	98.7	11,115	93,270	11.9	80.9	11,400	93,447	12.2
All combined	98.7	14,269	97,112	14.7	89.8	14,727	97,297	15.1
AAUP CATEGORY IIB (Baccalaureate)								
Public	99.9	14,852	89,172	16.7	96.1	15,199	89,845	16.9
Private-independent	99.5	13,204	109,460	12.1	89.4	13,353	109,716	12.2
Religiously affiliated	100.0	11,581	84,176	13.8	84.9	11,708	84,176	13.9
All combined	99.7	13,009	97,751	13.3	89.1	13,190	98,110	13.4
AAUP CATEGORY III (Associate's with ranks)								
Public	98.3	14,509	90,142	16.1	94.2	13,943	89,666	15.5
AAUP CATEGORY IV (Associate's without ranks)								
Public	98.3	16,613	91,802	18.1	95.7	16,905	92,370	18.3
ALL AAUP CATEGORIES COMBINED EXCEPT IV								
Public	98.9	14,899	115,214	12.9	93.6	14,877	114,768	13.0
Private-independent	98.9	16,520	145,829	11.3	88.8	17,129	141,378	12.1
Religiously affiliated	99.4	12,904	105,789	12.2	83.9	13,233	105,893	12.5
All combined	99.0	15,034	120,155	12.5	91.7	15,147	118,668	12.8

Note: The table is based on 715 reporting institutions. Figures represent institutions that provided medical benefits data. Coverage represents eligibility regardless of whether the institution contributes to the medical plan, per Internal Revenue Service guidelines for reporting fringe benefits. Prior to 2024–25, this table reported only coverage (eligibility) and did not separately report participation. Forty-one institutions only reported coverage (eligibility) and did not report participation. The "total compensation" statistic was eliminated in 2019–20 to reduce the number of benefit items to three: retirement, medical, and dependent tuition. Medical benefits include contributions by the institution, state, and local government to premiums for insurance plans combining medical, dental, and other health care but exclude long-term disability, Medicare, life insurance, health savings account contributions, and other benefits that were historically collected as "other benefits in kind." There were no private-independent or religiously affiliated institutions in categories III or IV.

SURVEY REPORT TABLE 10

Institutions providing a dependent tuition benefit to full-time faculty, by AAUP category and affiliation, 2025–26

	Dependent tuition benefit							
	All combined		Public		Private-independent		Religiously affiliated	
Dependent tuition waiver	*N*	Percent	*N*	Percent	*N*	Percent	*N*	Percent
AAUP CATEGORY I (Doctoral)	128		77		37		14	
Full (institution)	52	40.6	20	26.0	21	56.8	11	78.6
Partial (institution)	63	49.2	49	63.6	11	29.7	3	21.4
Full (specified institutions)	18	14.1	3	3.9	10	27.0	5	35.7
Partial (specified institutions)	35	27.3	23	29.9	8	21.6	4	28.6
Competitive scholarship programs	44	34.4	14	18.2	17	45.9	13	92.9
Other	32	25.0	15	19.5	13	35.1	4	28.6
Depends on years of service or other factors	45	35.2	15	19.5	20	54.1	10	71.4
None	5	3.9	4	5.2	1	2.7	0	0.0
AAUP CATEGORY IIA (Master's)	197		68		52		77	
Full (institution)	137	69.5	19	27.9	48	92.3	70	90.9
Partial (institution)	44	22.3	33	48.5	4	7.7	7	9.1
Full (specified institutions)	55	27.9	3	4.4	13	25.0	39	50.6
Partial (specified institutions)	35	17.8	14	20.6	13	25.0	8	10.4
Competitive scholarship programs	120	60.9	5	7.4	48	92.3	67	87.0
Other	29	14.7	7	10.3	7	13.5	15	19.5
Depends on years of service or other factors	87	44.2	16	23.5	28	53.8	43	55.8
None	16	8.1	16	23.5	0	0.0	0	0.0
AAUP CATEGORY IIB (Baccalaureate)	129		20		50		59	
Full (institution)	90	69.8	5	25.0	33	66.0	52	88.1
Partial (institution)	30	23.3	10	50.0	15	30.0	5	8.5
Full (specified institutions)	47	36.4	3	15.0	14	28.0	30	50.8
Partial (specified institutions)	33	25.6	7	35.0	14	28.0	12	20.3
Competitive scholarship programs	93	72.1	5	25.0	40	80.0	48	81.4
Other	32	24.8	4	20.0	14	28.0	14	23.7
Depends on years of service or other factors	69	53.5	4	20.0	33	66.0	32	54.2
None	5	3.9	5	25.0	0	0.0	0	0.0
AAUP CATEGORY III/IV (Associate's)	43		43		0		0	
Full (institution)	21	48.8	21	48.8	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.
Partial (institution)	13	30.2	13	30.2	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.
Full (specified institutions)	5	11.6	5	11.6	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.
Partial (specified institutions)	4	9.3	4	9.3	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.
Competitive scholarship programs	2	4.7	2	4.7	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.
Other	5	11.6	5	11.6	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.
Depends on years of service or other factors	6	14.0	6	14.0	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.
None	6	14.0	6	14.0	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.
ALL AAUP CATEGORIES COMBINED	497		208		139		150	
Full (institution)	300	60.4	65	31.3	102	73.4	133	88.7
Partial (institution)	150	30.2	105	50.5	30	21.6	15	10.0
Full (specified institutions)	125	25.2	14	6.7	37	26.6	74	49.3
Partial (specified institutions)	107	21.5	48	23.1	35	25.2	24	16.0
Competitive scholarship programs	259	52.1	26	12.5	105	75.5	128	85.3
Other	98	19.7	31	14.9	34	24.5	33	22.0
Depends on years of service or other factors	207	41.6	41	19.7	81	58.3	85	56.7
None	32	6.4	31	14.9	1	0.7	0	0.0

Note: Dependent tuition benefits are collected as a series of multiple-choice items only. The items and their choices are: Tuition waiver at institution (Full, Partial, or None); Tuition waiver at specified institutions through a consortium or system (Full, Partial, or None); Competitive scholarship programs, such as Tuition Exchange (Yes or No); Tuition benefit depends on years of service or other factors (Yes, No, or Not applicable); Other dependent tuition benefits (with an open-text response field); and None. The "total compensation" statistic was eliminated in 2019–20 to reduce the number of benefit items to three: retirement, medical, and dependent tuition. Institutions may indicate multiple dependent tuition benefits; therefore, percentages within each AAUP category may not add up to 100. N.d. = no data.

SURVEY REPORT TABLE 11

Presidential salary, by AAUP category and affiliation, 2025–26 (dollars)

	Presidential salary							
	All combined				Public			
AAUP category	Average	Median	Minimum	Maximum	Average	Median	Minimum	Maximum
Category I (Doctoral)	751,863	672,365	331,532	2,028,000	723,678	651,084	331,532	2,000,000
Category IIA (Master's)	427,909	400,000	143,394	1,050,000	389,264	391,924	143,394	676,016
Category IIB (Baccalaureate)	429,618	375,000	143,394	1,318,111	337,173	314,364	143,394	699,000
Category III (Associate's with ranks)	376,092	332,106	200,236	624,240	376,092	332,106	200,236	624,240
Category IV (Associate's without ranks)	274,592	275,000	185,649	362,250	274,592	275,000	185,649	362,250

	Private-independent				Religiously affiliated			
	Average	Median	Minimum	Maximum	Average	Median	Minimum	Maximum
Category I (Doctoral)	903,326	850,000	450,000	2,028,000	778,361	837,517	375,091	990,000
Category IIA (Master's)	540,447	525,000	233,520	1,050,000	402,604	370,576	200,000	832,342
Category IIB (Baccalaureate)	526,509	500,000	235,000	1,318,111	383,797	358,938	149,880	770,000
Category III (Associate's with ranks)	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.
Category IV (Associate's without ranks)	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.

Note: The table is based on 475 reporting institutions. Figures represent base salary and exclude supplemental pay; however, for two institutions where supplemental pay far exceeded the presidents' base salaries, the salary figures used here include supplemental pay. There were no private-independent or religiously affiliated institutions in categories III or IV. N.d. = no data.

SURVEY REPORT TABLE 12

Comparison of average salaries of presidents and faculty, by AAUP category and affiliation, 2025–26

	Ratio of presidential salary to average full professor salary							
	All combined				Public			
AAUP category	Average	Median	Minimum	Maximum	Average	Median	Minimum	Maximum
Category I (Doctoral)	5.15	4.95	2.04	11.44	5.00	4.85	2.04	10.66
Category IIA (Master's)	4.06	3.82	1.47	10.44	3.55	3.55	1.47	7.28
Category IIB (Baccalaureate)	4.17	4.34	1.48	7.64	3.25	3.10	1.48	6.63
Category III (Associate's with ranks)	4.10	3.33	2.02	8.76	4.10	3.33	2.02	8.76
Category IV (Associate's without ranks)	3.45	3.51	2.16	4.89	3.45	3.51	2.16	4.89

	Private-independent				Religiously affiliated			
	Average	Median	Minimum	Maximum	Average	Median	Minimum	Maximum
Category I (Doctoral)	5.90	5.44	3.60	11.44	5.41	5.27	3.99	7.97
Category IIA (Master's)	4.71	4.57	2.81	10.44	4.27	4.25	2.85	7.08
Category IIB (Baccalaureate)	4.42	4.45	2.14	7.64	4.34	4.41	2.44	7.16
Category III (Associate's with ranks)	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.
Category IV (Associate's without ranks)	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.

Note: The table is based on 475 reporting institutions. Figures represent base salary and exclude supplemental pay; however, for two institutions where supplemental pay far exceeded the presidents' base salaries, the salary figures used here include supplemental pay. There were no private-independent or religiously affiliated institutions in categories III or IV. N.d. = no data.

SURVEY REPORT TABLE 13

Chief academic officer salary, by AAUP category and affiliation, 2025–26 (dollars)

	Chief academic officer salary							
	All combined				Public			
AAUP category	Average	Median	Minimum	Maximum	Average	Median	Minimum	Maximum
Category I (Doctoral)	481,870	430,648	193,865	1,478,011	473,015	414,865	251,569	1,478,011
Category IIA (Master's)	259,402	248,000	68,076	531,738	268,418	269,991	142,800	483,728
Category IIB (Baccalaureate)	219,841	209,800	75,489	436,000	201,860	206,050	142,800	305,000
Category III (Associate's with ranks)	241,677	220,000	129,589	416,150	241,677	220,000	129,589	416,150
Category IV (Associate's without ranks)	181,329	178,980	104,902	275,000	181,329	178,980	104,902	275,000

	Private-independent				Religiously affiliated			
	Average	Median	Minimum	Maximum	Average	Median	Minimum	Maximum
Category I (Doctoral)	525,522	441,430	220,000	956,150	492,591	528,379	193,865	650,000
Category IIA (Master's)	297,610	290,000	68,076	531,738	224,065	209,640	113,300	475,000
Category IIB (Baccalaureate)	245,857	234,481	104,499	436,000	204,743	197,050	75,489	375,000
Category III (Associate's with ranks)	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.
Category IV (Associate's without ranks)	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.

Note: The table is based on 469 reporting institutions. Figures represent base salary and exclude supplemental pay. There were no private-independent or religiously affiliated institutions in categories III or IV. N.d. = no data.

SURVEY REPORT TABLE 14

Chief financial officer salary, by AAUP category and affiliation, 2025–26 (dollars)

	Chief financial officer salary							
	All combined				Public			
AAUP category	Average	Median	Minimum	Maximum	Average	Median	Minimum	Maximum
Category I (Doctoral)	423,982	375,000	184,501	1,358,026	410,047	370,000	207,000	1,358,026
Category IIA (Master's)	256,892	241,216	125,888	902,303	239,308	240,420	140,000	393,900
Category IIB (Baccalaureate)	249,371	223,689	83,200	660,000	177,462	175,352	83,200	312,000
Category III (Associate's with ranks)	204,101	175,782	79,542	322,782	204,101	175,782	79,542	322,782
Category IV (Associate's without ranks)	160,897	156,850	103,505	255,000	160,897	156,850	103,505	255,000

	Private-independent				Religiously affiliated			
	Average	Median	Minimum	Maximum	Average	Median	Minimum	Maximum
Category I (Doctoral)	497,121	387,500	263,305	1,111,000	420,553	454,663	184,501	562,162
Category IIA (Master's)	334,867	301,000	175,000	902,303	227,546	213,942	125,888	501,122
Category IIB (Baccalaureate)	310,477	286,000	124,570	646,088	220,323	200,000	102,480	660,000
Category III (Associate's with ranks)	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.
Category IV (Associate's without ranks)	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.

Note: The table is based on 447 reporting institutions. Figures represent base salary and exclude supplemental pay. There were no private-independent or religiously affiliated institutions in categories III or IV. N.d. = no data.

SURVEY REPORT TABLE 15

Average amount paid to part-time faculty members for a standard course section, by AAUP category and affiliation, 2024–25 (dollars)

	Part-time faculty pay per section					
	All combined			Public		
AAUP category	Average	Minimum	Maximum	Average	Minimum	Maximum
Category I (Doctoral)	5,115	516	32,581	4,727	516	32,581
Category IIA (Master's)	3,629	600	21,000	3,976	600	15,500
Category IIB (Baccalaureate)	4,804	750	33,280	4,145	750	10,000
Category III (Associate's with ranks)	3,575	1,000	12,250	3,575	1,000	12,250
Category IV (Associate's without ranks)	3,348	700	10,500	3,348	700	10,500
All combined	4,093	516	33,280	4,110	516	32,581

	Private-independent			Religiously affiliated		
	Average	Minimum	Maximum	Average	Minimum	Maximum
Category I (Doctoral)	5,342	1,000	28,139	6,227	1,033	16,500
Category IIA (Master's)	3,591	900	12,000	3,200	923	21,000
Category IIB (Baccalaureate)	6,320	1,000	33,280	3,537	1,000	15,000
Category III (Associate's with ranks)	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.
Category IV (Associate's without ranks)	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.	n.d.
All combined	4,121	900	33,280	4,000	923	21,000

Note: This table is based on 428 reporting institutions. Pay is collected for the prior academic year, 2024–25, to enable institutions to report data for an entire academic year. The standard course section is three credit hours, with some exceptions; see notes to Appendix III. Minimum pay reported as less than $500 per section or more than $50,000 is excluded from the table and analysis but is listed in Appendix III. There were no private-independent or religiously affiliated institutions in categories III or IV. For definitions of categories, see Explanation of Statistical Data. N.d. = no data.

SURVEY REPORT TABLE 16

Institutional contribution to part-time faculty retirement and medical benefits, by AAUP category, 2024–25

	Percentage of institutions contributing to benefits for part-time faculty							
	Retirement				Medical			
AAUP category	*N*	All	Some	None	*N*	All	Some	None
Category I (Doctoral)	85	10.6	31.8	57.6	84	2.4	40.5	57.1
Category IIA (Master's)	200	4.5	19.0	76.5	200	1.0	22.5	76.5
Category IIB (Baccalaureate)	125	1.6	30.4	67.2	124	0.0	26.6	72.6
Category III/IV (Associate's)	52	26.9	26.9	46.2	47	0.0	48.9	51.1
All combined	462	7.4	25.3	67.1	455	0.9	29.7	69.2

Note: Benefits are collected for the prior academic year, 2024–25, to enable institutions to report data for an entire academic year. The proportion of part-time faculty receiving benefits was reported as All, Some, or None for each institution. Percentages may not sum to 100 because of rounding.

SURVEY REPORT TABLE 17

Number of institutions included in full-time faculty salary tabulations, by AAUP category and affiliation, 2025–26

AAUP category	All combined	Public	Private-independent	Religiously affiliated
Category I (Doctoral)	218	148	48	22
Category IIA (Master's)	304	145	65	94
Category IIB (Baccalaureate)	171	33	72	66
Category III (Associate's with ranks)	57	57	0	0
Category IV (Associate's without ranks)	18	18	0	0
All combined	768	401	185	182

Note: For definitions of categories, see Explanation of Statistical Data.

SURVEY REPORT TABLE 18

Number of faculty members included in full-time faculty salary tabulations, by AAUP category and affiliation, 2025–26

AAUP category	All combined	Public	Private-independent	Religiously affiliated
Category I (Doctoral)	236,664	176,700	45,559	14,405
Category IIA (Master's)	86,978	57,205	13,457	16,316
Category IIB (Baccalaureate)	23,289	4,198	11,996	7,095
Category III (Associate's with ranks)	9,625	9,625	0	0
Category IV (Associate's without ranks)	2,678	2,678	0	0
All combined	359,234	250,406	71,012	37,816

Note: For definitions of categories, see Explanation of Statistical Data.

Explanation of Statistical Data

FULL-TIME FACULTY. The full-time faculty members reported in the survey are those who meet the US Department of Education's eligibility criteria for full-time instructional staff in the Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS) Human Resources survey component.

Institutions are asked to include (a) full-time faculty members who are on the payroll of the institution as of November 1, 2025, and working nine-, ten-, eleven-, or twelve-month contracts; (b) full-time "Primarily Instructional" and "Instructional/Research/Public Service" faculty members whose regular assignment has an instruction component (including release time for research), regardless of whether they are formally designated as "faculty" and irrespective of tenure status; (c) faculty members who are working on a reduced load (for example, 0.75 FTE) but who are still considered full-time in the institution's human resources or payroll system; (d) full-time faculty members who are on sabbatical or leave with pay; and (e) replacement faculty members for those on sabbatical or leave without pay, but only if the replacement faculty members are employed full time.

Institutions are asked to exclude (a) faculty members who are working on contracts of less than nine months; (b) clinical or basic science faculty, medical faculty, and/or military faculty paid on a different scale from civilian employees; (c) extreme outliers, meaning faculty members whose base salary falls well outside the norm for a particular rank; (d) faculty members on sabbatical or leave without pay; (e) replacement faculty members for those on sabbatical or leave with pay; (f) research faculty members and other faculty members who do not have a contractual instructional role, such as research assistant or associate, research professor, postdoctoral research fellow, or research fellow; (g) faculty members on courtesy appointments and other faculty members whose services are valued by bookkeeping entries rather than by full cash transactions, unless their salaries are determined by the same principles as those who do not donate their services; and (h) contributed service personnel, or administrative officers with titles such as provost, dean, associate or assistant dean, librarian, counselor, registrar, or coach, even though they may devote part of their time to classroom instruction and may have faculty status.

The academic ranks assigned to full-time faculty members are those determined by the reporting institution. Not all institutions use all ranks, and the definitions vary by institution. Institutions have been instructed to report "teaching" faculty members (for example, "Associate Teaching Professor") at the same rank used in their titles, regardless of their tenure status. Institutions have been instructed to report "visiting" faculty members and those with instructional postdoctoral appointments at the rank of instructor. Instructions for reporting visiting faculty were updated in 2024–25 to ensure consistent reporting and now state that visiting appointments are short-term, non-tenure-track positions held by individuals who ordinarily continue to hold tenured or tenure-track positions at other academic institutions. In the past, the AAUP asked that full-time faculty members with "visiting" in their titles be reported in the category of "instructor," but in recent years it became clear that some institutions assign "visiting" titles to faculty members holding other types of non-tenure-track appointments. In such cases, faculty members should be reported at their named ranks.

"No rank" full-time faculty members meet the other criteria for inclusion, regardless of whether they are formally designated as "faculty." They may have titles such as "artist in residence" or "scholar in residence." Institutions that do not assign faculty rank are instructed to report all full-time faculty members as "no rank." (See also the definition of institutional category IV below.)

PART-TIME FACULTY. The part-time faculty members reported in the survey are those who were paid per course section and defined by their institutions as employed less than full time. As with full-time faculty members, part-time faculty members are those included in the US Department of Education categories of "Primarily Instructional" and "Instructional/Research/Public Service," regardless of whether they are formally designated as "faculty." Clinical or basic science faculty in schools of medicine, as well as military faculty, are excluded. Individuals employed to meet short-term needs (for example, to cover a few weeks of a course) and students in the Federal Work-Study Program are excluded, even if their work has an instructional component.

The course sections for which part-time faculty pay is reported are those meeting the definition of an undergraduate class section in the Common Data Set for 2024–25 (http://www.commondataset.org/), item I–3: "an organized course offered for credit, identified by discipline and number, meeting at a stated time or times in a classroom or similar setting, and not a subsection such as a laboratory or discussion session. Undergraduate class sections are defined as any sections in which at least one degree-seeking undergraduate student is enrolled for credit. Inclusion criteria were modified in 2023–24 to include part-time faculty members who taught distance-learning (online or remote) course sections, unless they were paid on a different scale from those who taught in-person course sections. Inclusion criteria were modified in 2025–26 to include part-time faculty members who taught dual-enrollment course sections, unless they were paid on a different scale from those who taught regular undergraduate course sections. Exclude noncredit classes and individual instruction such as dissertation or thesis research, music instruction, or one-to-one readings. Exclude students in independent study, co-operative programs, internships, foreign language taped tutor sessions, practicums, and all students in one-on-one classes." (Also see the notes for survey report table 15 and appendix III.)

SALARY. This figure represents the contracted academic-year salary for full-time faculty members excluding summer teaching, stipends, extra load, or other forms of remuneration. Department heads with faculty rank and no other administrative title are reported at their instructional salary (that is, excluding administrative stipends). Where faculty members are given duties for eleven or twelve months, salary is converted to a standard academic-year basis as determined by the institution. The factor used to convert salaries is reflected in the notes to appendixes I and II.

CHANGE IN SALARY FOR CONTINUING FACULTY. The change in salary reported is for those 2024–25 full-time faculty members who remained employed as full-time faculty at the same institution and at the same contract length for 2025–26. The change includes both promotions in rank and increases (or decreases) due to other factors.

BENEFITS. These figures represent contributions by the institution, state, and local government on behalf of individual faculty members and do not include employee contributions. Benefit coverage represents eligibility regardless of whether the institution contributes to the benefit plan, per Internal Revenue Service guidelines for reporting fringe benefits. Prior

to 2024–25, the survey collected data only on benefit coverage (eligibility) and did not separately collect data on benefit participation. The benefits reported in the survey include (a) retirement plan contributions, regardless of vesting provisions, excluding payments for unfunded retirement liability, prepaid retiree health insurance, and Social Security; (b) medical insurance contributions, including premiums for insurance plans combining medical, dental, and other health care, but excluding long-term disability, Medicare, life insurance, and Health Savings Accounts; and (c) tuition benefits available to faculty dependents. As with salary figures, retirement figures are converted to a standard academic-year basis as determined by the institution. Medical insurance contributions are not converted to an academic-year basis. Dependent tuition benefits were collected for full-time faculty as a series of multiple-choice items only (see survey report table 10). In 2023–24, the "Institution is a member of Tuition Exchange" field was changed to "Competitive scholarship programs, such as Tuition Exchange." In 2025–26, the "Tuition benefit varies based on years of service or other factors" field was changed to "Tuition benefit depends on years of service or other factors." For part-time faculty, retirement and medical benefits were collected as categorical variables only (see survey report table 16). Not all institutions reported all items. Institutions were asked to provide their best estimate of the data for the entire academic year.

INSTITUTIONAL CATEGORIES. AAUP institutional categories are assigned to institutions by the AAUP Research Office based on the following institutional characteristics:

Category I (Doctoral). Institutions characterized by a significant level and breadth of activity in doctoral-level education as measured by the number of doctorate recipients and the diversity in doctoral-level program offerings. Institutions in this category grant a minimum of thirty doctoral-level degrees annually, from at least three distinct programs. Awards previously categorized as first-professional degrees, such as the JD, MD, and DD, do not count as doctorates for this classification. Awards in the category of "doctor's degree–professional practice" are reviewed on a case-by-case basis.

Category IIA (Master's). Institutions characterized by diverse postbaccalaureate programs (including first professional) but not engaged in significant doctoral-level education. Institutions in this category grant a minimum of fifty postbaccalaureate degrees annually, from at least three distinct programs. Awards of postbaccalaureate certificates are reviewed on a case-by-case basis.

Category IIB (Baccalaureate). Institutions characterized by their primary emphasis on undergraduate baccalaureate-level education. Institutions in this category grant a minimum of fifty bachelor's degrees annually, from at least three distinct programs, and bachelor's and higher degrees make up at least 50 percent of total degrees awarded.

Category III (Associate's with ranks). Institutions characterized by a significant emphasis on undergraduate associate's degree education. Institutions in this category grant a minimum of fifty associate's degrees annually. Associate's degrees make up at least 50 percent, and bachelor's and higher degrees make up less than 50 percent, of total degrees and certificates awarded. Faculty members are distinguished on the basis of standard academic ranks (professor, associate professor, and so forth). Associate's institutions without standard academic ranks should be included in category IV.

Category IV (Associate's without ranks). Institutions characterized by the criteria for category III but without standard academic ranks. An institution that refers to all faculty members as "instructors" or "professors" but does not distinguish among them on the basis of standard ranks should be included in this category. However, if an institution utilizes another ranking scheme that is analogous to the standard ranks, it can be included in category I, II, or III as appropriate.

The AAUP institutional category assigned to an institution may change after the institution has met the criteria for another category for three consecutive years; exceptions are made on a case-by-case basis.

ABBREVIATIONS USED IN APPENDIXES I AND II. Academic Ranks: PR = Professor; AO = Associate Professor; AI = Assistant Professor; IN = Instructor; LE = Lecturer; NR = No Rank; AR = All Ranks. All institutions that do not assign professorial ranks are listed in appendix II.

Col. (1) Institutional Category—The definition of AAUP institutional categories is given above.

Col. (2) Institutional Control—PU = Public; PI = Private-Independent; FP = Private For-Profit; PR = Private-Religiously Affiliated.

Col. (3) Average Salary by Rank and for All Ranks Combined—This figure has been rounded to the nearest hundred. "All Ranks Combined" includes the rank of lecturer and the category of "No Rank." Salary averages are replaced by a dash (—) when the number of individuals in a given rank is fewer than three.

Col. (4) Percentage of Faculty Covered for Benefits and Benefits as a Percentage of Average Salary—Percentage of full-time faculty members (all ranks combined) who are eligible to be covered and average total expenditures for full-time faculty members who are eligible to be covered as a percentage of the average salary for all full-time faculty members. RET = Retirement benefits (as defined above); MED = Medical benefits (as defined above).

Col. (5) Dependent Tuition Benefit—F = Full tuition waiver at this institution; P = Partial tuition waiver at this institution; f = Full tuition waiver at specified institutions through a consortium or system; p = Partial tuition waiver at specified institutions through a consortium or system; T = Institution is a member of Tuition Exchange; O = Other (with an open-text response field); V = Tuition benefit depends on years of service; N = None.

Col. (6) Percentage of Faculty by Tenure Status—T = Tenured; TT = Tenure-Track; NTT = Non-Tenure-Track. The figures represent the total number of full-time (FT) faculty members with a given tenure status.

Col. (7) Percentage Increase in Salary for Continuing Faculty—The percentage increase in salary for those 2024–25 full-time faculty members who remain employed as full-time faculty at the institution for 2025–26 at the same contract length. This represents the average increase for individuals as opposed to a percentage change in average salary levels.

Col. (8) Number of Faculty Members by Rank and Gender—The figures represent the total number of full-time (FT) faculty members in a given rank by gender.

Col. (9) Average Salary by Rank and by Gender with Salary-Equity Ratios—Same definition as that given for col. (3) but by gender. Salary-equity ratio is the ratio of women's to men's average salaries, multiplied by 100.

ABBREVIATIONS USED IN APPENDIX III

Col. (1) Institutional Category—The definition of AAUP categories is given above.

Col. (2) Institutional Control—The definition of institutional control is given above.

Col. (3) Part-Time Faculty Pay—NO. = The number of part-time faculty members paid on a per-section basis. MIN. ($) = Minimum pay for a standard course section, whether from actual data or by policy. MAX. ($) = Maximum pay for a standard course section, whether from actual data or by policy. AVG. ($) = Average (mean) pay for a standard course section.

Col. (4) Part-Time Faculty Benefits—RET = The proportion of part-time faculty members receiving an institutional contribution toward retirement benefits. MED = The proportion of part-time faculty members receiving an institutional contribution toward health-care benefits. None = no part-time faculty are eligible to receive benefits; Some = some part-time faculty are eligible to receive benefits; All = all part-time faculty are eligible to receive benefits.

Col. (5) Calendar—The institution's academic calendar.

Appendixes I, II, and III are published with the Faculty Compensation Survey results on the AAUP's website. See https://www.aaup.org/our-work/research/FCS.

Any inquiries concerning the data in this report may be directed to the AAUP Department of Research and Public Policy. Email: aaupfcs@aaup.org.

Faculty Compensation Survey Data Submission and Results Portal: https://research.aaup.org.

AAUP interactive data website: https://data.aaup.org.

STATEMENT ON DATA QUALITY

The AAUP Faculty Compensation Survey collects data from colleges and universities across the United States through an online portal. These data are reviewed through our internal verification process. Whenever the AAUP believes an error may have occurred, we ask institutional representatives to review the specific issues we identify. Nearly all institutions comply with our requests for additional review. If resubmitted data meet our internal standard, they are approved for inclusion in published tables and appendixes. Questionable data without an institutional response may be excluded.

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